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16 अक्टूबर | सुबह 11:30 बजे

5 अक्टूबर | दोपहर 3:00 बजे

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PICNIC TRAGEDY
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EDITORIAL AND OPINION PAGES



IRANI CUP
J&K bowlers keep RoI batters in check
SPORT » PAGE 18

UAE probes ‘terror’ link to flight incident

Netanyahu says attacker had undergone ‘Islamist radical indoctrination’; he credits passengers of flight and Indian pilot for averting catastrophe

Agence France-Presse
DUBAI

The UAE announced on Thursday it was probing a possible “terrorist” link to an apparent attack by a pilot on board a flight from Dubai to Tel Aviv that saw passengers reroute the plane to stop it from crashing.

The dramatic events on Wednesday ended with passengers being given a hero’s welcome by Israel Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu as they arrived from Saudi Arabia, where the plane made an emergency landing earlier.

Mr. Netanyahu credited the flydubai pilot, Indian national Smit Machchhar, as well as passengers with averting catastrophe, after a co-pilot allegedly stabbed him and tried to crash the plane. Passengers de-

Warm welcome: Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu with Yaniv Hayun, a passenger on the flight, on Thursday. REUTERS

scribed rushing to the cockpit after the plane suddenly plummeted, losing around 17,000 feet of altitude in the span of a minute, according to the Flightradar24 website.

Israeli officials have called the incident “an attempted terrorist attack”.

Mr. Netanyahu said the co-pilot had undergone “Islamist radical indoctri-

nation... The attacker, he calls out to the aircrew, ‘Kill me, kill me,’ making it clear he was suicidal”.

U.S. President Donald Trump said there might be an “Iran link” to the co-pilot.

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RELATED REPORTS ON
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Govt. hikes commercial LPG cylinder price by ₹65

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

The price of commercial LPG cylinders was increased by around ₹65 on Thursday. The hike, for the second consecutive month, has come just ahead of the festive season.

Cumulatively, the price of the 19-kg cylinder has been increased by about ₹75 per refill since September across two tranches.

The price of the 5-kg free-trade LPG cylinder refills was hiked by ₹15 per cylinder on Thursday even as the price of domestic LPG remained unchanged. The price of aviation turbine fuel was increased by about ₹16 to ₹137 per litre.

The latest increase in the price of commercial LPG cylinders follows the price cuts in July and August.

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Shivakumar protests; EC orders probe into Form 7 fraud charge

Rishita Khanna
BENGALURU

D.K. Shivakumar staging a protest outside the CEO's office in Bengaluru. J. ALLEN EGENUSE

The Election Commission (EC) on Thursday ordered a probe into the filing of Form 7s in bulk seeking deletions of names from final electoral rolls following a five-hour protest by Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar and his Cabinet colleagues.

Chief Electoral Officer, Karnataka, V. Anbu Kumar, directed all Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) to take action against applicants who “knowingly” make false statements or declarations while filing claims or objections in Forms 6, 6A, 7, and 8.

Mr. Shivakumar withdrew the protest after the announcement.

Earlier in the day, he alleged that “pre-filled” Form 7s were filed in bulk across the State by the Opposition BJP and Janata Dal (Secular) workers, target-

ing Muslims, and members of the Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and Other Backward Classes, claiming they had either “shifted” or were “absent”.

He said many Form 7s were either false or forged.

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CM YK



A ND-NDE

Cong. sacks Punjab unit chief amid internal rift; new PCC chief soon

Warring resigns from the post after being informed of the decision; with Assembly poll due next year, front runners include ex-MP Vijay Inder Singla, MP Gurjeet Singh Aujsla, LoP Partap Singh Bajwa and senior leader Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

Bowing to mounting pressure from a section of “disgruntled” State party leaders who were pushing for change at the top, the Congress’s central leadership has removed Punjab Pradesh Congress Committee (PPCC) president Amarinder Singh Raja Warring from his post. Mr. Warring stepped down after he was informed about the party’s decision, sources said on Thursday. Though Mr. Warring did not comment on his resignation, he changed his bio on X to ‘former PPCC President’. The party is likely to an-



Amarinder Singh Raja Warring stepped down after he was informed about the party’s decision, sources said on Thursday. FILE PHOTO

nounce the new State unit chief within a day or two, a source said. The Assembly poll is due in the State next year. Front runners for the post include former Minister and former MP Vijay In-

der Singla, Lok Sabha MP Gurjeet Singh Aujsla, Leader of the Opposition in the Assembly Partap Singh Bajwa, and senior leader Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa, who recently met party president Mallikarjun

Kharge, a source said. The power tussle, particularly between former Chief Minister Charanjit Singh Channi and Mr. Warring, has been out in the open for the past few months. Last month, the party’s central leadership replaced Bhupesh Baghel with Sachin Pilot as party in-charge for Punjab, succumbing to pressure from the disgruntled leaders. Mr. Warring has also been removed in a bid to pacify such leaders, a source said. In July, a reshuffle of posts in the State party unit triggered internal unrest. While Mr. Warring was retained as State party president, Mr. Channi was given charge of the election cam-

paign committee for the 2027 Assembly poll. **Ouster sought** Mr. Channi, along with a few other party leaders, was reportedly unhappy with the new arrangement. The disgruntled leaders and their supporters demanded Mr. Warring’s removal as PPCC chief, bringing the State unit’s divisions out in the open. Last week, a meeting took place at the residence of Mr. Kharge, in which senior party leader Rahul Gandhi and Mr. Pilot were present. Mr. Pilot then submitted a detailed report about the State unit’s affairs in Punjab, based on feedback from party leaders, to the top leadership.

Political tensions spike in Keralam amid protests, clashes

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Political tensions in Keralam have spiked over the past few days with the State witnessing pitched street battles between the activists of the Congress and the Communist Party of India (Marxist) as well as the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and their respective youth and student organisations. Congress workers waved black flags as Union Home Minister Amit Shah’s convoy passed through Kollam district on September 26, part of the Congress’s nationwide campaign demanding the exit



Senior CPI(M) leaders marching towards the Secretariat in Thiruvananthapuram on Thursday. NIRMAL HARINDRAN

of Gyanesh Kumar as Chief Election Commissioner (CEC). This led to counter protests by the Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha (BJYM) supporters against Congress leader and MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, Ministers

and at Congress offices in various districts over the past few days. On Wednesday, Minister for Local Self Government K.M. Shaji’s vehicle was blocked by BJYM workers in Thiruvananthapuram. Later in the evening, vio-

lence broke out during the Youth Congress march demanding the resignation of the CEC. The Students’ Federation of India (SFI) accused the Youth Congress and Congress-affiliated Kerala Students’ Union workers of hurling flaming torches inside the Kerala University hostel grounds, while the Youth Congress accused the SFI of throwing stones at the protest march. Subsequent police action drew sharp criticism from the SFI and senior CPI(M) leaders. On Thursday, the official vehicle of Sports Minister O.J. Janeesh was allegedly attacked by CPI(M)-affiliated Democratic Youth Fed-

eration of India members at Kannur, drawing sharp condemnation from Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan. While Mr. Satheesan asked why the CPI(M) was getting distressed over demonstrations against the BJP as well as the CEC and accused the party of provoking Wednesday’s clashes, Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan said the Youth Congress protest, which was ostensibly against the Sangh Parivar and the CEC, was “a calculated act of violence” staged to appease the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh and divert public attention from the government’s administrative failures.

Parth Pawar holds 99% stake in Amadea, says HC

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

The Bombay High Court on Thursday recorded that Parth Pawar, son of Maharashtra Deputy CM Sunetra Pawar and a Rajya Sabha MP, holds 99% stake in Amadea Enterprises LLP. The firm had bought 40 acres of land in Mundhwa

HC imposes ₹10,000 cost on CM Soren

Press Trust of India
RANCHI

The Jharkhand High Court on Thursday imposed a cost of ₹10,000 on Chief Minister Hemant Soren after his counsel sought an adjournment in ED officers’ plea, challenging criminal proceedings against them in a case linked to their 2024 search at his Delhi residence.

Timings			
DELHI			
FRIDAY, OCT. 02			
RISE	06:14	SET	18:06
RISE	22:21	SET	12:08
SATURDAY, OCT. 03			
RISE	06:15	SET	18:05
RISE	23:27	SET	13:09
SUNDAY, OCT. 04			
RISE	06:15	SET	18:04
RISE	00:00	SET	14:02
Delhi Weather			
Delhi City	max 34	min 22	
Safdarjang	34	22	
Palam	32	21	

Delhi Palam Today
34°C Morning will be pleasant with mist and haze. The weather will be dry. Day will be warm. Night also will be pleasant.

Delhi Palam Tomorrow
35°C The weather will be dry. Day will be warm. Night will be pleasant.

British Sikh national gets bail in 7 UAPA cases

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

British Sikh national Jagtar Singh Johal walked out of Tihar Jail on Thursday after the Delhi High Court granted him bail in seven cases registered under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act. The court observed that he had spent

more than eight years in custody and the trial was unlikely to conclude soon. A Bench noted that despite the Supreme Court directions, the pace of the trial had not picked up. The cases relate to a series of alleged targeted killings and attempted killings in Punjab’s Ludhiana and Jalandhar during 2016-17.

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• NOIDA, Nirula's Sec-2, Near Metro Station, Sec-15, Noida, UP
• LAJPAT NAGAR, 49, Main Ring Road, Adj. Haldi Ram, Near Moolchand Crossing

AJP questions educational credentials of BJP candidates

Rahul Karmakar
GUWAHATI

The Assam Jatiya Parishad (AJP) has questioned the educational credentials of 13 Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) candidates for the Silchar Municipal Corporation election on October 3. AJP leader Kunki Chowdhury said her party had filed complaints, but the State Election Commission and district-level poll authorities failed to take necessary steps. “The affidavit of Kan- chan Deb, the BJP’s candi- date for Ward 6, says he ob- tained a BA degree from Sikkim International Un- iversity in 2018. However, the university was set up in



AJP leader Kunki Chowdhury. FILE PHOTO

2021,” she told journalists on September 30. Ms. Chowdhury also cited the case of Uttam Kumar Gowa- la, the BJP’s candidate for Ward 39. She said his affida- vit showed he cleared Class 10 in 1999 and Class 12 in 2024. “We sought clarifica-

tion on the huge gap.” She also questioned the educational qualifications of Pratiksha Deb and Pa- plee Karmakar, the BJP’s candidates for Ward 14 and Ward 15. The two obtained degrees from a university in Jodhpur in 2013 and 2019 respectively. Ms. Chowdhury referred to media re- ports saying the university has faced allegations of is- suing fake degrees. Earlier, a Silchar court is- sued a summons to Ataur Rahman Laskar, the BJP’s candidate for Ward 17, after three persons challenged his educational claims. His affidavit said he acquired a BA degree from a “contro- versial” Sikkim-based university.

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Sakthi Financial Services Limited | Sakthi Institute of Information and Management Studies
Nachimuthu Gounder Rukmaniammal Higher Secondary School

INBRIEF



Patient’s death not linked to my convoy, says Assam CM

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Thursday said stopping the ambulance to let his convoy pass is not related to the patient’s death, and asserted that no inconvenience should be caused to people due to his or any Minister’s movement. The patient, Rasuraj Chakraborty of Sribhumi, was being shifted to the Silchar Medical College Hospital on Wednesday when the ambulance carrying him was stopped to let the Chief Minister’s convoy pass. He died in the hospital on Thursday morning. “The patient was suffering from a critical liver ailment and his death is not related to the brief halt,” Mr. Sarma said.

MMRDA starts digital system for project-affected families

The Mumbai Metropolitan Region Development Authority (MMRDA) on Thursday launched ‘e-Punarvasan’, a digital rehabilitation and resettlement (R&R) system aimed at verifying project-affected families through Aadhaar and preventing ineligible beneficiaries from receiving homes. MMRDA Commissioner Sanjay Mukherjee issued possession letters to 94 eligible slum dwellers from Bandra’s Garib Nagar. The system integrates surveys, electricity bill and Aadhaar-based OVSE verification, computerised allotment, possession letters and digital monitoring. Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis said it would reduce improve transparency.

Cong. accuses U.P. govt. of creating ‘one district, one mafia’ model in State

Day after Supreme Court rap for U.P. Police, State’s AICC in-charge says comments reflect ‘anarchy prevailing under BJP rule’; Akhilesh Yadav says police are behaving like workers of the ruling party

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Thursday attacked the BJP government in Uttar Pradesh over the law and order situation, alleging that Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath had created a “one district, one mafia” model in the State with criminals enjoying political protection.

The party alleged that the vulnerable sections, including Dalits, were bearing the brunt of what it described as a “nexus between criminals and those in power”.

Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Thursday also alleged that Uttar Pradesh Police was “working like a BJP worker”, citing the Supreme Court’s recent criticism, and called for ousting the ruling party to resolve the “crisis”. “The Supreme Court and the High Court have repeatedly said what we have been saying - the police cannot be trusted. Police are working like BJP workers,” Mr.



U.P. has on average witnessed nine murder and 10 attempted murder cases every day, said AICC in-charge Rajendra Pal Gautam. FILE PHOTO

Yadav said at a press conference in Lucknow.

His remarks came a day after the Supreme Court criticised Uttar Pradesh Police during a hearing in a molestation case from Bulandshahr. The Bench of Justices Sanjay Kumar and Sanjeev Sachdeva said, “It is better if we ask the CBI to step in and take over all U.P. Police investigations. We might as well disband U.P. Police. This nonsense has to stop at some point.”

All India Congress Committee (AICC) in-charge of Uttar Pradesh Rajendra Pal Gautam claimed that the State had witnessed, on av-

erage, nine murders, 10 attempts to murder, nine rapes, 33 kidnappings and around 235 violent crimes every day.

Mr. Gautam also referred to recent observations by the Supreme Court and the Allahabad High Court on the functioning of the Uttar Pradesh police, claiming that those reflected the “anarchy prevailing under BJP rule” in the State. Congress leader Abhay Dubey alleged that the Adityanath government had provided such protection to criminals that they had begun “harassing the public openly”. “The State

records the highest number of acid attacks on daughters,” he said.

Mr. Dubey alleged that the Chief Minister had established a “one district, one mafia” model and that criminals belonging to a particular caste were being shielded. “Today, the people of Uttar Pradesh are asking Yogi Adityanath: how long will this reign of terror continue?” he said.

Congress Lok Sabha member from Saharanpur Imran Masood alleged that “only hatred is being spread” in Uttar Pradesh. “The talk here is not about uniting, but only about dividing,” he said.

On party reshuffle

Mr. Gautam also spoke about the ongoing speculation regarding a change in the leadership of the Uttar Pradesh Congress Committee. He said the decision rested with the party’s central leadership. “This is a matter for the leadership; it does not fall within my ambit,” he said.

(With inputs from PTI)

Volunteers detained in Haryana ahead of CM’s visit, alleges CJP

The Hindu Bureau
GURUGRAM

Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) leader Sudhir Sangwan alleged that several party volunteers were detained or placed under house arrest across Haryana ahead of Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini’s visit to Hisar on Thursday, amid protests over the Common Eligibility Test (CET).

According to Mr. Sangwan, the CJP had submitted memoranda supporting the protesting students in 14 districts on September 28. He alleged that the police subsequently identified party volunteers associated with the programme. “In Haryana, the police are illegally detaining CJP colleagues because they had submitted a memorandum to DC Jhajjar the day before yesterday... in support of the CET students Hisar protest,” Mr. Sangwan posted on X on Wednesday night.

Mr. Sangwan claimed that the volunteers were picked up without prior notice or legal proceedings.

He said that the three volunteers detained in Jhajjar were released after noon on Thursday after being picked up on Wednesday night.



Nayab Saini assured the protesters that their demands would be looked into. FILE PHOTO

day night. Chandramohan, a CJP member, told *The Hindu* that he was detained from his home in Jhajjar district around 7.30 p.m. on Wednesday. He alleged that the personnel did not show him any document or explain the reason for his detention.

Additional DGP (Law and Order) Sanjay Singh said, “We do not have any information. It is to be decided locally by concerned units as per the situation.”

CM’s assurance

On Thursday, Mr. Saini met the protesters and assured them that their demands, including annual conduct of the CET, permanent local employment, an end to contractual recruitment, etc. would be looked into. Subsequently, the protesters decided to postpone the stir till December 6.

Soon after SIR process, Chief Electoral Officer of Odisha opts for voluntary retirement

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

Odisha’s Chief Electoral Officer R.S. Gopalan has applied for voluntary retirement from service after the process of special intensive revision (SIR) got over in the State. The 1968-born and 2001-batch IAS officer applied for VRS on Wednesday. Odisha’s final electoral roll was published on September 21. “I applied for VRS on personal grounds, and it has nothing to do with the SIR process. I have already completed 25 years of service. I became eligible for a full pension on September 2, 2025,” Mr. Gopalan told *The Hindu*.

‘A smoother exercise’

With one and a half years left for his retirement, Mr. Gopalan oversaw the SIR process in Odisha, which, according to him, was



Applied for VRS on personal grounds, it has nothing to do with the SIR process, said R.S. Gopalan (centre). FILE PHOTO

smoother than in other States. “We heard 58 lakh anomalies and disposed of them. Had I been under any pressure because of the SIR, I would have tendered my resignation then. The SIR process was completed in Odisha without any unpleasant incident,” he said.

The Opposition Biju Janata Dal, however, had submitted several memoranda alleging the exclusion of voters from the electoral roll. “The timing of his VRS

raises suspicions, particularly at a time when Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar is under tremendous pressure over the ‘Vote Chori’ allegations. It appears that his decision to take VRS was driven by pressure from the Chief Election Commissioner or the State government,” said Odisha Pradesh Congress Committee president Bhakta Charan Das, who described Mr. Gopalan as “absolutely honest”.

Cracks widen within ruling UDF as Congress leaders speak out against Keralam govt’s style of functioning

NEWS ANALYSIS

S. Anandan
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Signs of an imminent implosion within Keralam’s ruling United Democratic Front (UDF), particularly within its lead party the Congress, were apparent on Thursday when UDF convener Adoor Prakash openly expressed his displeasure over UDF chairman and Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan’s “unilateral” style of functioning.

Mr. Prakash’s criticism was not an isolated expression of resentment. He was echoing the sentiments of several senior Congress leaders, some of whom shared similar concerns in off-the-record conversations with *The Hindu*.

Mr. Prakash’s unusual outburst conveys the impression that matters have come to a head. Demand has been rife within the



UDF chairman and Keralam Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan

Congress for a reorganisation of the State party unit, given that many office-bearers, including State unit chief Sunny Joseph, also hold ministerial portfolios, leaving them with little time for organisational work and little command over the government.

A senior Congress leader and member of the Political Affairs Committee said in exasperation that the high command has left the party in the lurch. “Our concerns have been shared with Deepa Dasmunsi, the All India Congress Committee (AICC) general se-

cretary in charge of Kerala. The person who must act is K.C. Venugopal, the AICC general secretary in charge of organisation, but he too is biding his time after losing the chief ministerial race despite having greater support among party legislators,” the leader said.

‘Returning favour’

The reported appointment of M.K. Muneer, a leader of the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML), a constituent of the UDF, as chairman of the Administrative Reforms Commission, a post with Cabinet rank, has also irked some, who have termed it “needless” and “politically damaging”.

“The IUML had vociferously backed Mr. Satheesan’s claim for chief ministerial rank and, it appears, he’s returning the favour,” a Congress leader said.

After securing a wafer-thin majority in the 2011 Assembly poll, the then Oommen Chandy-led UDF

government was forced to do a tightrope walk, conceding to the IUML’s controversial demand for a fifth Cabinet Minister in 2012. “But the Congress is in a far better position now and there is no real compulsion to give the post of Administrative Reforms Commission chairman to the IUML on a platter,” another leader said.

The Bharatiya Janata Party has not taken kindly to the move, with senior leader K. Surendran and MLA V. Muraliedharan viewing it as the IUML prevailing over Mr. Satheesan.

Some Congress leaders said All India Forward Bloc leader G. Devarajan, reportedly appointed the government’s special representative in Delhi with Cabinet rank, lacked the clout or bargaining power to be of any help to the State. A Delhi-based leader would have fit the bill, a party leader said. “Come to think of it, do we really

need these posts any longer, if not for accommodating favourites?” he added.

A senior leader, known for his “virtuous” stances, said Mr. Satheesan would be doing a great disservice to the party if he chooses to “follow in the footsteps of his predecessor [former Chief Minister and CPI(M) leader Pinarayi Vijayan]” in public comportment, handling of the media, and on issues of transparency.

“He has now given the weekly Cabinet briefing a miss. When questions were asked about the sponsors of his chartered flight [to flood-hit Malappuram district recently], he could have cleared the air. The public ought to know who is footing the Chief Minister’s airfare,” he said.

With the Congress high command stuck in a wait-and-watch mode, more party leaders are likely to go public with their criticism of the UDF government in the coming days.

Drug menace takes centre stage in BJP’s Punjab poll campaign as it cuts across caste, religion and age

NEWS ANALYSIS

Vikas Vasudeva
CHANDIGARH

The drug menace in Punjab has stayed at the centre stage of political and social attention for more than a decade and because it cuts across caste, religion and age, it appears to have become a major political issue for the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

With an eye on the Assembly election, which is due in early 2027, the BJP had launched its ‘Nasha Mukht Punjab Yatra’ campaign on September 18, under which party leaders and workers undertook four separate marches from different locations to



Farmers and BJP workers take part in a tractor march during the ‘Nasha Mukht Punjab Yatra’ near Ghanaur, in Patiala. FILE PHOTO

cover all 117 Assembly constituencies of Punjab. The campaign culminated in Jalandhar on September 30, where Union Home Minister Amit Shah urged voters to give the BJP a chance to form the next government and promised to make Punjab free of the drug menace by December 31, 2029.

The saffron party, which has historically struggled to make inroads in Punjab, is aggressively pushing its campaign around the drug menace issue to get a foothold in the border State.

Despite repeated promises to eradicate it, successive governments have failed to address the drug

menace. Before the 2017 Assembly election, then Congress leader Captain Amarinder Singh had, while taking an oath of *Gutka Sahib* (a small book with sacred verses from *Guru Granth Sahib*), promised the people of the State to stamp out the menace of drugs within four weeks of assuming power. The Congress ruled from 2017 to 2022, yet the drug problem remained. The now-ruling Aam Aadmi Party made a similar promise in 2022, saying it would end the drug menace within four months of forming the government. Four and a half years later, the problem continues to plague the State. The Shiromani Akali Dal and the BJP have also faced public wrath over

the drug menace when, as alliance partners, they ruled the State from 2007 to 2017. Their opponents accused them of letting the illegal drug trade flourish under their regime.

Pointing to substance abuse, health and social surveys have indicated that Punjab could have between 1 lakh and 2.7 lakh people who were dependent on opioids. Findings from the study in 2017, which was carried out over the preceding two years, titled ‘Epidemiology of Substance Use and Dependence in the State of Punjab’, released by the Post-graduate Institute of Medical Education and Research, revealed that about one in every 87 persons was dependent on drugs.

MLC poll: JD(U)’s Anant Singh escorts Oppn. candidate to file nomination, calls for his victory

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

Janata Dal-United (JD-U) MLA and *bahubali* (strongman) Anant Singh on Thursday travelled in an open jeep to accompany the Opposition Jan Suraj Party’s (JSP) candidate, Anuj Singh, as the latter filed his nomination papers for the forthcoming State Legislative Council election from the Patna graduates’ constituency. Mr. Anant Singh declared that he would ensure Mr. Anuj Singh’s victory “at any cost”. The JD(U) is the ruling National Democratic Alliance’s (NDA) ally in Bihar. Mr. Anant Singh, who represents the Mokama con-

stituency in the Bihar Assembly, has been defying the candidature of party spokesperson Neeraj Kumar to the seat, claiming he would “ensure Neeraj Kumar’s defeat at any cost as he has sought to defeat me four times during Assembly elections”.

Eight State Legislative Council seats in Bihar – four graduates’ and four teachers’ constituencies – go to the polls on October 23, 2026.

“I do not know what the party line is as, in this (MLC) election, there is no need to contest on a party’s symbol. The fact remains that he (Neeraj Kumar) has opposed me four times in Assembly elections. So I

will oppose him in the same way this time and ensure his defeat, come what may,” Mr. Anant Singh told media persons while accompanying Mr. Anuj Singh.

Bitter rivals

Mr. Neeraj Kumar has been elected from the Patna graduates’ constituency thrice. He was bitter that Mr. Anant Singh had contested several times as an Independent candidate from Mokama since 2015, snapping ties with the JD (U), sources said, while the party fielded Mr. Neeraj Kumar against Mr. Anant Singh from the seat the latter had won by comfortable margins.

Veeramani, two associates booked under Goondas Act

R. Sivaraman
CHENNAI

Greater Chennai Police Commissioner A. Amalraj has ordered the detention of Gem Granites founder R. Veeramani, 84, and his associates, Shanthi, 60, and her husband Mahendra Simhan, 63, under the Goondas Act for allegedly engaging in repeated criminal activities and disturbing public order. The Immoral Trafficking Prevention Unit arrested Veeramani on August 29, on charges of sexually assaulting minor girls, and the other two accused for abetting him. They were remanded in judicial custody and lodged at the Central Prison in Puzhal. Subsequently, the police registered two more cases

against Veeramani for driving minor girls to suicide. A press release from the office of Commissioner said the action was taken as part of the police's efforts to curb the activities of habitual offenders. Meanwhile, the police released an update on further action in the child sexual abuse case involving Veeramani. They said they were probing the financial transactions made by the businessman. The police said that so far, four cases have been registered under various provisions of the law based on complaints. (Assistance for overcoming suicidal thoughts is available on the State's health helpline 104 and Sneha's suicide prevention helpline 044-2464 0050)

A.P. HC strikes down 34% BC quota in local body elections

Court says the reservation exceeds the 50% threshold laid down by the Supreme Court; it further directs State government and State Election Commission to begin poll process within six weeks

V. Raghavendra
VIJAYAWADA

A Division Bench of the Andhra Pradesh High Court, comprising Chief Justice Lisa Gill and Justice Challa Gunaranjan, on Thursday set aside Government Orders 105 and 1065 through which the government provided 34% reservation to the Backward Classes (BCs) in Panchayat Raj Institutions (PRIs) and 33.33% quota in the Urban Local Bodies (ULBs). The court said that they exceeded the 50% threshold laid down by the Supreme Court. While striking down the impugned G.O.s, the court



The High Court gives liberty to the State to revisit the issue and determine the percentage of reservation for BCs. FILE PHOTO

gave liberty to the government to revisit the issue and determine the percentage of reservation for BCs keeping in view the apex court judgment in *Janhit Abhiyan vs Union of India* after completing the exercise of data collection in compliance with the judg-

ment in *Vikas Kishanrao Gawali vs State of Maharashtra*. The judges have expressed the opinion that the empirical data collected by the State through unified family survey cannot form the basis of declaration for reservation for the BCs. In the same vein, the

court directed the State government and the State Election Commission (SEC) to expeditiously commence the process of holding elections to the PRI and ULBs preferably not later than six weeks from October 1. Continued operation of electoral rolls in existence on the qualifying date cannot be affected by the special intensive revision (SIR) and it cannot be the reason for postponement of the elections, the judges said. On delimitation of Municipalities and Municipal Corporations, they said the Census Act of 1948 or Census Rules, 1990 do not prohibit the State from undertaking the process.



On September 27, LPU students held a massive protest during which police vehicles were attacked. ANI

Punjab campus violence: 3, including one student, arrested

Press Trust of India
PHAGWARA

Three persons were arrested in connection with the violence on the Lovely Professional University (LPU) campus in Punjab's Phagwara, police said on Thursday. One of the three is an LPU student, a resident of Sonipat in Haryana. The other two are locals of Phagwara, the police said. The accused were produced before a court here on Thursday, which sent them into three days' police remand. On September 27, LPU students held a massive protest during which they blocked a stretch of the Delhi-Amritsar Highway outside the campus over a claim that a plumber had raped a female student on the university premises. Later that evening, the protesting students allegedly pelted police personnel with stones and attacked their vehicles, leaving several cops injured, officials said. Students also alleged that some outsiders with

their faces covered damaged property, ransacked shops and set several places on fire on the LPU campus. **Police probe** The police has registered an FIR against an unidentified person under Section 64 (rape) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and a special investigation team was constituted to probe the matter on the basis of students' allegations, even though the university authority denied claims of any rape incident on campus. The alleged victim or her family is yet to be ascertained, according to police sources. Three separate cases were also filed against unidentified persons in connection with the violence, arson, damage to property, and blockade of the highway. On September 28, a large number of students left for their homes after the suspension of classes for 10 days and postponement of mid-term examinations.

ED takes up ₹100-cr. cheating case against former T.N. Minister

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has launched a probe into an alleged ₹100-crore cheating case against former Tamil Nadu School Education Minister Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi, B.T. Arasakumar and others. The agency had registered a case based on the FIR filed by the Central Crime Branch (CCB), and had begun tracing the money trail, sources said. The

CCB arrested Mr. Arasakumar, who claimed to be the founder-president of the Tamil Nadu Private Schools Association, an unregistered body, in June. He and the other accused allegedly collected more than ₹100 crore from several private school managements by claiming that he had contacts in the government, and could secure permissions and approvals for establishing and upgrading schools and obtain other necessary

orders. Subsequently, Sections 7 and 12 of the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988, were added to the FIR. According to the FIR, Mr. Arasakumar induced private school administrators to pay him money by promising to secure government approvals and other official orders. The FIR also refers to a previous case of a similar nature registered against him in Crime No. 8 of 2013 by the District Crime Branch, Pudukottai.

Saudi's execution of Mahe man leaves expats worried

The Hindu Bureau
MALAPPURAM

Abootti Valliyil, 41, from Peringadi in Mahe, Kerala, was executed at Dammam prison in Saudi Arabia on September 27 after being arrested in a drug case. His family said he was deceived into driving a vehicle across the Saudi-Oman border on December 2, 2023, unaware that 43 kg of methamphetamine was hidden inside the fuel tank.

He was working at a mobile shop in Oman when a customer from Kannur, who had offered to help him secure a job and a Saudi visa, asked him to drive the vehicle across the border. Saudi authorities intercepted and arrested him. Initially sentenced to 25 years in prison and fined one million Saudi riyals, he was later given the death sentence. Abootti is survived by his mother, wife, two children, and three sisters.

The family alleged that the Kannur man admitted to the deception and offered a financial settlement, but failed to secure Abootti's release. His execution has renewed concern among expatriates regarding Indians facing drug-related cases in Gulf countries. For Abootti's family, however, the immediate priority is justice. They want authorities to investigate the incident and take action against those responsible.

INBRIEF



MRPL offers ₹1.2 cr. aid to kin of employee who died in fire

Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals Limited (MRPL) on Thursday announced compensation of ₹1.2 crore to the family of 30-year-old contract employee Manish Karkada, who died in a fire in the unit, while a group of contract employees carried out a protest in front of the company's gate demanding adequate compensation to the deceased and other injured persons. MRPL said it will give financial support of ₹90 lakh to the family. Besides, the family was eligible for about ₹10 lakh under Group Term Life Insurance and ₹20 lakh under Workmen Compensation Policy.

Bolarum arms theft accused wanted to sell stolen weapons

Former Army havaladar Upputholla Mallesh, accused of stealing 12 firearms and over 1,800 rounds of ammunition from the 20 Battalion, Madras Regiment premises at Bolarum, was sent back to judicial remand after his 10-day police custody ended. During questioning, Mallesh named seven others who helped him steal the cache. Investigators said the theft was driven both by Mallesh's grudge against his former superiors and an intention to illegally sell the stolen firearms and ammunition for money.

Association of Malayalam film actors gets new office-bearers

Actors Asha Aravind and Sijoy Varghese have been elected as the vice-presidents of the Association of Malayalam Movie Artistes (AMMA) in a revamp after the actors' body plunged into organisational turmoil following the general body meeting in Kochi on June 21, 2026. An executive committee meeting of the association held here on Wednesday elected them to the posts of vice-president, which had remained vacant after the resignation of actors Lakshmi Priya and Jayan Cherthala. Neena Kurup is the new treasurer and Sarayu Mohan is the new joint secretary.

Kerala HC stays trial in journalist death case for one month

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Kerala High Court has stayed for one month the trial into the death of journalist K.M. Basheer after a car allegedly driven by IAS officer Sriram Venkitaraman rammed his two-wheeler in Thiruvananthapuram in Kerala in 2019. The High Court stayed the trial after Basheer's wife, Jaseela, sought the appointment of a new special prosecutor in the case. This came after the government informed the court on September 17 that there was no need to replace the current prosecu-

tor with a special prosecutor. The government had earlier informed the court that it had taken an in-principle decision to appoint a special prosecutor. Ms. Jaseela questioned the prosecution's handling of the case, arguing that the prosecutor lacked the experience to manage a trial involving nearly 100 witnesses. The court has now directed the government to submit before it the files regarding its earlier in-principle decision to appoint a special prosecutor. Mr. Venkitaraman faces charges of culpable homicide, destruction of evidence and drunken driving.

Gandhi tribute



All set: Preparations under way at Hyderabad's LB Stadium for Gandhi Jayanti celebrations on October 2. G. RAMAKRISHNA

TPCC alleges pre-printed deletion forms; seeks probe

Swathi Vadlamudi
HYDERABAD

A complaint to Chief Electoral Officer C. Sudharshan Reddy by the Telangana Pradesh Congress Committee (TPCC) about pre-printed applications for bulk deletion of voter names in the Musheerabad constituency has opened a can of worms, adding to fears about a particular section of the electorate being targeted during the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. While allegations are being made about applications for bulk deletion of electors in Karnataka, in Telangana, fresh allegations are about an application by a booth-level agent (BLA) of the Bharatiya Jana-

TPCC raised concerns over the circulation of pre-printed application; CEO assures scrutiny

ta Party (BJP) from Musheerabad submitting Form-7 applications seeking deletion of names of the Congress's BLA and over 30 members of his family. The names of all the family members along with the address were pre-printed on the forms, with only the name of the applicant hand-written, raising suspicions about a large-scale political conspiracy. TPCC has raised serious concerns about pre-printed application forms being prepared and circulated on

a wider scale targeting Congress leaders and their supporters, and expressed suspicion that BLAs may have got the material through party channels. It sought thorough investigation into the matter and action against the errant. **Thorough scrutiny** Mr. Reddy said that bulk applications for deletion of electors submitted by anybody will undergo thorough scrutiny before the deletions are effected. While Election Commission of India has clarified that any registered voter within a specific constituency could submit any number of forms, it has also said that a single person filing more than five objections will trigger a review.

Kodagu poll booth sees bulk Form 7 filing against Muslims

Rishita Khanna
BENGALURU

In a similar trend seen across multiple Assembly constituencies in Karnataka, where pre-filled Form 7 applications were filed in bulk seeking deletion of Muslim voters' names, at least 50 applications were filed against Muslim names at a single polling station at the Government Higher Primary School at Bydagotta in Kodagu district on September 23 alone. The objectors said the forms had been sent from the "party office". All the applications cited "absent" as the reason for deletion. Data accessed by *The Hindu* shows that at least 50 Form 7 applications were filed by objec-

5 FIRs registered across Karnataka

A total of five FIRs were registered across Karnataka on Thursday, over the submission of Form 7 applications in bulk, seeking the deletion of the names of voters predominantly from the minority and Dalit communities during the ongoing SIR. Three FIRs named BJP members as the accused.

tors named Rajni, B.N. Basavaraju, Lokesh, Savitha Malali, and A.C. Nagaraj. However, officials in Somwarpet where the polling station is, said they had not received any of these applications. When contacted by *The*

Hindu, Mr. Basavaraju and Ms. Rajni said they had filed 10 applications each, claiming they had "doubts" that the voters had "duplicate" entries. Asked why "absent" had been cited as the reason when they had claimed the voters had duplicate entries, the objectors said they did not know the details and had followed instructions from the party office in Somwarpet. They further declined to name the party but added that five people were given 10 forms each. However, it is to be noted that the forms were already printed with the voters' names and EPIC numbers, similar to applications seen in other constituencies.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

OBITUARY



T.M. HARIHARAN
Advocate, High Court
S/o. Late T.R. Mani
Senior Advocate

Date of Demise: 30.09.2026

A life defined by kindness, integrity and quiet strength. His warmth and guidance remain with us every day.

DEEPLY MOURNED BY

Family, Juniors and Staff
70101 33663
TSR Venkatramana (Uncle)
98401 28718
Mahesh Srinivasan
(Brother in law)

For enquiries on announcements in this section, please contact our office at the following number between 10a.m. to 8p.m.

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OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER, CONSTRUCTION DIVISION (E/M), U.P. JAL NIGAM (URBAN), 4/4, SANJAY PLACE, AGRA
Letter No.: 1257/Nivida/18
Dated : 29/09/2026

SHORT TERM E-TENDER NOTICE

U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban), online e-tender in two bid system on percentage rate basis for Supply, Installation, commissioning and Testing of Non-Clog Sewage Submersible Pump sets at Main Pumping station (M.P.S.) Rukmani Vihar & (M.P.S.) Rajpur Khadar under Vrindavan Sewerage scheme, Distt.- Mathura of above said works under Deposit work programme are hereby invited on "TURNKEY" basis from the reputed contractors/firms having requisite work experience & financial capabilities. The bidders should submit their bids only if they consider themselves eligible and are in possession of all the requisite documents. The works includes **Supply, Installation, commissioning and Testing of Non-Clog Sewage Submersible Pump sets of above said works as per specification.** E-bid documents will be available on U.P. Govt. e- procurement portal <https://etender.up.nic.in> and U.P.J.N. (Urban) website www.jn.upscd.gov.in for download from dated 06.10.2026 from 15:00 hrs. E-bids can be submitted till 21.10.2026 up to 17.00 hrs. Technical bid shall be opened on 23.10.2026 at 15:00 hrs. in the office of the Executive Engineer, Construction Division (E/M), U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban), Agra, in presence of contractor or their authorized representative who wish to participate, E-tender Cost is Rs. 2000.00 + GST @ 18%. Details are available on U.P. Govt. e-procurement portal <http://etender.up.nic.in> & U.P.J.N website www.jn.upscd.gov.in.

MAHARASHTRA METRO RAIL CORPORATION LTD.
Maha Metro, Block No. A3, Food Grain Godown, Near Civil Court, Next to Kamgar Putala Vasahat, Shivajinagar, Pune - 411005
e-mail: tenders.pmp@mahametro.org
Website: www.punemetrorail.org
E tender portal: <https://mahatenders.gov.in>
Telephone: 020-26051074

NOTICE INVITING TENDER (NIT)

Tender Notice No. P1-0&M-25/2026 Date: 02.10.2026

Name of Work: Annual Rolling Shutter Maintenance of 30 Nos of Elevated & Underground Stations and 2 Depots of Pune Metro Project for a period of One Year

Tender available from 16:00 Hrs. on 09/10/2026 to 16:00 Hrs. of 22/10/2026.

For all above Tenders Interested bidders may visit Pune Metro Rail website www.punemetrorail.org or Download the Tender documents and obtain further details regarding the Tender from e-tender portal of Govt. of Maharashtra <https://mahatenders.gov.in>.

AGM (Procurement & Contracts)
Maharashtra Metro Rail Corporation Limited.
Maha Metro, Greenest Metro

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OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER, GANGA JAL PROJECT UNIT, U.P. JAL NIGAM (URBAN)
Pratap Vihar, Ghaziabad.
E-mail:- pmgangajalgzb@yahoo.com

Letter No: 1638 /Nivida/91
Date: 01.10.2026

E-Tender Notice

U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban) online e-tenders for execution of "Development of Horticultural Works at 120 MLD WTP Campus under Combined 50 Cusec, Water Supply Scheme, Siddharth Vihar, Ghaziabad." Bids are invited in two bid system on percentage rate basis from eligible reputed and experienced bidders. E-tender documents will be available for download from **08.10.2026 at 17:00 Hrs.**, Pre-Bid meeting will be held on dated **15.10.2026 at 14:00 hrs.** in the office of undersigned. E-bid can be submitted till **07.11.2026 up to 14:00 Hrs.** and technical bid shall be opened on **07.11.2026 at 16:00 Hrs.** in the office of The Executive Engineer, Gangajal Project Unit, U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban), Ghaziabad in presence of contractor or their authorized representative. E-tender Cost is Rs. 5000.00+GST @18%. Details are available on U.P. Govt. e-procurement portal <http://etender.up.nic.in> & U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban) website www.jn.upscd.gov.in.

TO ADVERTISE PLEASE CONTACT

Mr. N SELVA KUMAR

PH: 9820350726

selvakumar.n@thehindu.co.in

THE HINDU
India's National Newspaper

NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY

E-Tender Notice

Dy.CME/Plant for Chief Workshop Manager, N. E. Railway, Mechanical Workshop, Gorakhpur- for and on behalf of President of India invites tender through on-line E-Open Tender for the following work- **S. No.: 1., E-Tender Notice No. & Name of the work:** Tender No.-"26-GKP-MV5-2026-27", "Ultrasonic testing of LHB Wheel sets at Mechanical Workshop, Gorakhpur.", **Estimated cost (in Rs.):** 3801112.00, **Earnest Money (in Rs.):** 76000.00, **Last date of tender submission:** Upto 11.00 Date: 24.10.2026, **Cost of the Tender forms-** Zero, **Period of Contract:** 12 Months. The details of above tenders are also available on Indian Railway website "http://www.ireps.gov.in".
Dy.CME/Plant Mechanical Workshop, CPRO/Mech-91 Gorakhpur
Do Not Smoke Bid/Cigarette in train

HIMACHAL PRADESH STATE ELECTRICITY BOARD LIMITED
'A State Govt. Undertaking'
*** NOTICE INVITING TENDER ***
(e- Tendering Mode only)

Online tender (Two part bid) are invited for the supply of following item (s), on the prescribed form (Tender Documents), The Start, End dates and times of submission and opening of Techno Commercial Bid of tender are as per detail given below. The Detailed Tender Notice, terms and conditions along with tender documents can be viewed / downloaded from website <https://www.hptenders.gov.in>

Sr. No	Tender No.	Description of Items	Completion Period	Cost of Tender document inclusive of GST @ 18% (Non-refundable) (In ₹)
1.	CE/MM-13/2026	Engagement of Consultancy services for undertaking a comprehensive technical study to assess the impact of Renewable Energy (RE) integration, particularly Solar PV generation on the EHV Transmission and Distribution network of HPSEBL in Una and Kangra Districts.	6 Months	1475/-

Date of online publication and download of tendered documents from website : 14.10.2026
Start date & time of bid submission.: 14.10.2026 (from 06:00 P.M.)
End date & Time of bid Submission.: 16.11.2026 (upto 11:00 A.M.)
Date & Time of opening of Techno Comm. bid.: 18.11.2026 (at 03:00 P.M.)

Chief Engineer (MM), HPSEB Ltd., Vidut Bhawan, Shimla-171004.

HP / 1029/26-27

Government of Jammu and Kashmir
Jal Shakti Department
Office of the Executive Engineer Flood Control Division Anantnag
Phone Fax: 01932464212, 225119 D.C Office Complex Anantnag192101

RENTENDER Corrigendum

Subject: This office e-NIT No. 16of 2026-27Dated: -07-09-2026
Reference: 01. Issued under this office No. FCD/Ang/2026/3662-84.07-09-2026

Due to "Nil response" against S. No. 20 and non-qualification of the bid against S. No. 21 of the subject e-NIT, the works are hereby retendered as detailed below:

S. No.	Description	Date	Time		
		DD	MM	YYYY	
1	Publishing date of NIT	01	10	2026	09:00.AM
2	Download start date	01	10	2026	09:00.AM
3	Bid submission start date	01	10	2026	09:00.AM
4	Bid submission end date	05	10	2026	06:00 PM
5	Bid opening date	06	10	2026	10:00 AM

All other terms and conditions will remain unchanged.

NO. FCD/Ang/2026/4506-21
Dated: -30-09-2026

Sd/-
Executive Engineer,
Flood Control Division Anantnag

DIPK-6317/26

JAMMU AND KASHMIR POLICE
DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS JAMMU
0191-2561578 (O), 0191-254780 (F),
email-sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in

Hue and Cry Notice Rule No. 712/191

Dy. SP HQ, Jammu has intimated that accused person namely Satpal S/O Makhri Ram R/O House Colony Sec. 14, Sonipat Haryana is evading his arrest/wanted in case FIR No. 76/2007 U/S 379/367/368 RPC, of P/S Nowabad, Jammu, since the commission of crime. Despite repeated raids/efforts the accused could not be traced/still absconded.

It is therefore requested that Hue and Cry Notice of above mentioned accused is being published for the information of Police establishments / Public in general having any clue related to the whereabouts / present location of above named accused, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact / Telephone numbers.

Description Roll :-

Name : Satpal
S/O : Makhri Ram
Address : House Colony Sec. 14, Sonipat Haryana

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-

1. DPO, Jammu : 0191-2547807, 0191-2561578
2. SSP Jammu Mail I.D : sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in
3. PCR Jammu : 0191-2605949
4. SP City South : 0191-2433778
5. Dy. SP Hqrs. : 0191-2562259
6. SHO P/S Nowabad : 0191-2565274

Sr. Superintendent of Police Jammu

DIP/J-11467/26 Sep 30 2026

Government of Jammu and Kashmir
Jal Shakti Department
Office of the Executive Engineer Flood Control Division Anantnag
Phone Fax: 01932464212, 225119 D.C Office Complex Anantnag192101

Corrigendum

Subject: This office e-NIT No. 16of 2026-27Dated: -07-09-2026
Reference: - 01. This Office retender Corrigendum NO.4506-21 Dated 30-09-2026
Due to typographical Error please read as follows: -

Please Read This	Instead of This
01 Bid submission end date (06-10-2026)06:00PM	05 10 2026 06:00 PM
02 Bid opening date (07-10-2026) 10:00 AM)	06 10 2026 10:00AM

NO. FCD/Ang/2026/4522-37
Dated: -30-09-2026

Sd/-
Executive Engineer,
Flood Control Division Anantnag

DIPK-6319/26

Government of Odisha
Information & Public Relations Department
Lok Sampark Bhawan, Bhubaneswar
File No. IPR-FP-IITF-0002-15323 / IPR, Bhubaneswar, Dated 30/09/2026

REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL

01. Director, I&PR Department, Government of Odisha (The Client) invites Request For Proposal (RFP) from the eligible bidders to Conceptualize, Design and Fabricate the Odisha Pavilion at India International Trade Fair (IITF) - 2026, Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi.

02. Key objectives, scope of work, eligibility requirement, layout plan, technical specifications and other details may be seen in and downloaded from <https://inpr.odisha.gov.in/> or, <https://odisha.gov.in>.

03. Last date for receipt of sealed proposal is **14.10.2026 by 05:00 PM.**

04. RFP will be opened on **15.10.2026 at 11:30 AM** in the Conference Hall, Lok-Sampark Bhawan, Unit-V, Keshari Nagar, Bhubaneswar.

05. Pre-Bid consultation with intending bidders is scheduled to be held on **06.10.2026 at 11:30 AM** in the Conference Hall, Lok-Sampark Bhawan, Unit-V, Keshari Nagar, Bhubaneswar.

06. The I&PR Department have the right to accept or reject the Tender(s) without assigning any reason thereof.

07. Corrigendum, addendums, clarifications or cancellations if any shall only be published in the above-mentioned websites.

DIRECTOR, I&PR
15001/106/2627
OIPR-15001/15001/1/26-27/0106

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
HIGHER EDUCATION DEPARTMENT
Lokseva Bhawan, Sachivalaya Marg, Bhubaneswar-751001
PT2-HE-SCH-POLICY-0001-2022/52861 /HE, Bhubaneswar, Dated:01/10/2026

Corrigendum-I

NOTICE INVITING RFP FOR SELECTION OF A CONSULTING FIRM/ ENTITY FOR ESTABLISHMENT OF STATE TECHNICAL SUPPORT GROUP (STSG) FOR SUPPORTING IMPLEMENTATION OF PRADHAN MANTRI UCHCHATAR SHIKSHA ABHIYAN (PM-USHA) IN HIGHER EDUCATION DEPARTMENT, GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA

RFP No. PM-USHA:05/2026 Date: 17.09.2026

Sl. No.	RFP Cl. No.	Page No.	Description as per RFP	Now Modified Provisions
1	DATA SHEET (Sl. No.8 & 9)	4	Last Date & Time for receiving of Bid - 05/10/2026 At 5:30 PM	Last Date & Time for receiving of Bid - 15/10/2026 till 5:30 PM (Registered Post & Speed Post only)
2		4	Date & Time of Opening of Technical Bid: 06/10/2026 at 3:30 PM	Date & Time for Opening of Technical Bid -16/10/2026 at 3:30 PM

All other terms and conditions of the RFP remain unchanged.

Joint Secretary to Govt. & SPD, RUSA / PM-USHA
11001/352/2627
OIPR-11001/11001/1/26-27/0065

JAMMU AND KASHMIR POLICE
DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS JAMMU
0191-2561578 (O), 0191-254780 (F),
email-sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in

Hue and Cry Notice Rule No. 712/191

Dy. SP HQ, Jammu has intimated that accused person namely Sohan Singh S/O Teja Singh R/O Patel Nagar, Jammu is evading his arrest/wanted in case FIR No. 63/19981 U/S 307/201/147/148 RPC, of P/S Nowabad, Jammu, since the commission of crime. Despite repeated raids/efforts the accused could not be traced/still absconded.

It is therefore requested that Hue and Cry Notice of above mentioned accused is being published for the information of Police establishments / Public in general having any clue related to the whereabouts / present location of above named accused, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact / Telephone numbers.

Description Roll :-

Name : Sohan Singh
S/O : Teja Singh
Address : Patel Nagar, Jammu

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-

1. DPO, Jammu : 0191-2547807, 0191-2561578
2. SSP Jammu Mail I.D : sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in
3. PCR Jammu : 0191-2605949
4. SP City South : 0191-2433778
5. Dy. SP Hqrs. : 0191-2562259
6. SHO P/S Nowabad : 0191-2565274

Sr. Superintendent of Police Jammu

DIP/J-11546/26 Oct 1 2026

JAMMU AND KASHMIR POLICE
DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS JAMMU
0191-2561578 (O), 0191-254780 (F),
email-sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in

Hue and Cry Notice Rule No. 712/191

Dy. SP HQ, Jammu has intimated that accused person namely Sudershan Pardhan S/O Bandu Pardhan R/O Orrisa A/P Jammu is evading his arrest/wanted in case FIR No. 251/1978 U/S 457/380 RPC, of P/S Nowabad, Jammu, since the commission of crime. Despite repeated raids/efforts the accused could not be traced/still absconded.

It is therefore requested that Hue and Cry Notice of above mentioned accused is being published for the information of Police establishments / Public in general having any clue related to the whereabouts / present location of above named accused, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact / Telephone numbers.

Description Roll :-

Name : Sudershan Pardhan
S/O : Bandu Pardhan
Address : Orrisa A/P Jammu

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-

1. DPO, Jammu : 0191-2547807, 0191-2561578
2. SSP Jammu Mail I.D : sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in
3. PCR Jammu : 0191-2605949
4. SP City South : 0191-2433778
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DIP/J-11440/26 Sep 30 2026

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**गणितीय विज्ञान संस्थान, चेन्नई**
THE INSTITUTE OF MATHEMATICAL SCIENCES, CHENNAI
(Department of Atomic Energy, Govt. of India)

अक्टूबर / October 01, 2026

विज्ञापन संख्या / Advt No.04-R/IMSC/2026

गविस द्वारा नियमित संकाय पदों (7 वें सीपीसी के तहत वेतन मैट्रिक्स में स्तर-12 एवं स्तर-13) पर सीधी भर्ती हेतु ऑनलाइन आवेदन आमंत्रित किए जाते हैं। विस्तृत जानकारी के लिए, कृपया हमारी वेबसाइट देखें: <https://www.imsc.res.in/facultyrecruitment>

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Expression of Interest (EOI)

DTL intends to invite following Expression Of Interest (EOI):

Inviting stakeholder inputs and feedback to validate and strengthen the bidding process for establishing public EV charging and battery swapping infrastructure under the Delhi EV Policy, 2026.

For complete details of EOI please visit website:- <https://dtl.gov.in>.

Inputs may be submitted within **07 days** of this publishing through:
https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLSdWw_QD5i3Kh3fUL4idBISyNy4Yo3j9-eNIiWusZ2ZlQJfPg/viewform?pli=1&pli=1.

Any stakeholder / individuals willing to offer land parcels, parking areas or premises for the establishment of EV charging or battery swapping stations may furnish site details via:
<https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLSddpitB62KBfAjh8j2Yp9fOx8sBepLCH8Y7euKB DiP4rFAw/viewform?usp=preview>.

**Online Tender Notice : 91 (2026-27)**

Project Implementation Unit, Vadodara (Health and Family Welfare Department)

Superintending Engineer, Project Implementation Unit, Zone-6, G.M.E.R.S. Medical Hospital and College Campus, Near College Dome, Gotri, Vadodara-390001. Phone No. (0265) 2422993. Tenders are invited from eligible bidders for 01 to 02 work with an estimated cost of 1045.99 to 4826.92 lakhs. This work is sought through the online e-tendering system. The tender documents for Work No. 01 to 02 can be viewed on the website www.nprocure.com until 18:00 hours on 22/10/2026. For additional details, please visit the aforementioned website.

Note 1 - Original documents like Tender Fee, E.M.D., etc., are to be scanned and uploaded online and sent by R.P.A.D within 7 (seven) days.

(INF-VAD-849-26-27)

**Rajiv Gandhi University of Health Sciences, Karnataka**
4th T Block, Jayanagar, Bengaluru-560041
E-mail : registrar@rguhs.ac.in Tel : +91-80-29601928

PUBLIC NOTICE – 2026
ADVISORY TO STUDENTS, PARENTS AND CAREER ASPIRANTS

It has come to the notice of the University that certain individuals and institutions, including those operating outside Karnataka, are falsely claiming affiliation with Rajiv Gandhi University of Health Sciences (RGUHS) and are using such claims to solicit admissions from students. RGUHS was established under an Act of the Karnataka State Legislature, and its jurisdiction is limited to the State of Karnataka. The University has not affiliated any college, institution or course operating outside Karnataka.

The University therefore advises students, parents and career aspirants to exercise utmost caution and rely only on information published through the official RGUHS website and verified social media platforms.

Students and parents are advised to note:

- RGUHS has not affiliated any college or institution outside Karnataka.
- RGUHS does not offer any course through correspondence, distance learning or online mode.
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For authentic information regarding admissions, affiliated institutions, courses, sanctioned intake and other academic matters, please refer only to the official RGUHS website and verified social media platforms.

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DIPR/CP/3030/AKAR/2026-27

SPOTLIGHT



Medicines typically pass through manufacturers, clearing and forwarding agents, stockists, sub-stockists, and retailers before reaching a patient; each handover creates an opportunity for pilferage. ISTOCK/GETTY IMAGES

the reputation of the manufacturer. The packaging and labelling can also throw up red flags.”

He says while it is not a perfect system, hospitals do what they can to ensure that medicines are genuine. “Ideally, the government should facilitate more sampling and have more testing labs. The onus can only be on the government to make these checks. It isn’t possible for individual hospitals to do actual quality checks,” he says.

Dr. Shyam Agarwal, chairperson of the Department of Medical Oncology at Sir Ganga Ram Hospital, says when a patient reports that a medicine is not effective, doctors cannot establish whether the medicine itself is to blame.

“One way to avoid counterfeits is to ensure that the supply coming into hospitals is from genuine companies and that they are not offering steep discounts. A 50% discount should raise suspicion,” he says.

A broken chain

While investigations have traced the chain in such cases, the implications for patients are rarely known. Patients find it almost impossible to establish whether they have consumed a counterfeit medicine. In the case of the rabies vaccine, for instance, a government official says, “It is hard to trace how many patients have consumed it, and from where. If we circulate notices warning patients about a particular medicine, it might lead to more panic.”

The official adds that one way to check whether a patient has received a counterfeit medicine is to trace the batch number recorded on the bill.

Patient rights advocate Bejon Kumar Misra points out that there are not enough large-scale studies to ascertain the impact of counterfeit medicines and that even when data is recorded, it is rarely traced back to patients. “One of the major causes of the issue is that the lowest bidder ends up getting preference,” he says.



Investigators found original cartons and empty boxes being retained and reused. Batch numbers, MRP details, and other identifying marks were allegedly removed with chemicals like acetone before the medicines were repackaged

ADITYA GAUTAM
DCP, Crime Branch, Delhi Police

He adds that while many patients are affected, many do not even realise they have consumed counterfeit medicines and that the medicines are not working.

According to government data, drug regulators tested 1,41,322 samples across India in 2025-26. Of these, 3,012 were declared ‘Not of Standard Quality’ and 283 were found to be spurious or adulterated. State drug regulators initiated 779 prosecution cases for the manufacture, sale, and distribution of spurious or adulterated drugs.

When medicines fail silently

The consequences are most serious when the failure is not immediately visible.

In cancer treatment, a counterfeit or standard medicine may contain too little or none of the active ingredients needed to work. A patient may continue treatment believing therapy is being administered while the disease progresses. The delay in detecting treatment failure makes oncology one of the areas most affected by counterfeit medicines, Varma says. With emergency or other life-saving medicines, the consequences can be immediate. Incorrect ingredients or contamination can also cause harm independent of the illness being treated.

For the health industry, the damage extends beyond the patient. Manufacturers can face lost sales and complaints over products they did not make; legitimate distributors and pharmacies bear the cost of investigations and recalls; and repeated counterfeit incidents can erode confidence in genuine medicines and India’s pharmaceutical supply chain.

The answer has to move beyond periodic enforcement, Varma says. Manufacturers need tighter accounting of unused and returned vials, hospitals need records of who receives high-value injections and how empty vials are disposed of, and wholesalers and pharmacies need to conduct stronger checks on suppliers and maintain traceable purchase records.

The fear of fake

Every time Jharana Mallick, 32, who has thalassemia, goes to buy iron chelator medicines, she is careful about which company she picks and medical store she buys from, hoping she does not have to relive what happened 10 years ago.

“For a whole year, the medicines I bought from dispensaries had no effect. After five or six tests, I realised my serum ferritin levels were going up rather than coming down. And I simultaneously started developing issues like osteoporosis and even a gall bladder stone,” she says.

Originally from Odisha, she now lives in Delhi and undergoes frequent blood transfusions. Her mistrust extends beyond the medicines to the system itself. “These are supposed to be life-saving drugs, but they are bought at the lowest tendering costs,” says Mallick, who now works with a charitable trust, Sarvesham Mangalam Foundation, focussed on thalassemia awareness and prevention. In a month, she says, people living with thalassemia can spend up to ₹50,000 on drugs.

Doctors never told her that the medicines she took were counterfeit, she says. But the experience left her with a demand that goes beyond her own treatment: the system should stop “compromising on life-saving drugs”.

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Breaking the blister pack

Over the past few months, probe agencies have busted several major drug rackets involving counterfeit and adulterated pharmaceuticals, from cancer treatments and vaccines to antibiotics and psychotropic drugs. **Lavpreet Kaur** and **Ashna Butani** trace how fakes move through illicit supply chains and find that while many perpetrators may be caught, there is no system for tracking down victims at the receiving end

Rajkumari and Darshan, both in their mid-30s and from Jharkhand, are leaving Delhi’s All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS) after a check-up. They pause to collect themselves before navigating the medical stores outside. Rajkumari hangs on to her husband, who lugs an oversized bag that weighs him down. They have been given a list of medicines to buy.

Rajkumari was diagnosed with blood cancer about 10 months ago and referred to AIIMS for treatment. Since then, the couple has spent a large part of its savings on medicines, travel, and stay in Delhi. Darshan says he has sold their land to keep paying for the medicines.

He pulls out her prescription and points to a name. A single injection of the medicine costs around ₹1.5 lakh and his wife will need several vials. The drug is used in the treatment of blood and bone marrow cancers, including multiple myeloma. It is also among the high-value cancer medicines that figure in an investigation by Delhi Police’s Inter-State Cell into counterfeit and illegally diverted drugs. The racket, spread across Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, and Telangana, was busted in late August.

Aditya Gautam, Deputy Commissioner of Police, Crime Branch, says Delhi Police has so far arrested 17 people and recovered 588 filled vials and 3,021 other medicines, all valued at about ₹9 crore. “Investigators found original cartons and empty boxes being retained and reused. Batch numbers, MRP details, and other identifying marks were allegedly removed with chemicals like acetone before the medicines were repackaged,” he says.

The seized cancer drugs include Darzalex, Imfinzi, Erbitux, Opdivy, Gazvya, Bavencio, Adcetris, and Keytruda. Bavencio and Adcetris have been confirmed as counterfeit by the manufacturers; reports on the others are awaited.

A doctor at AIIMS involved in Rajkumari’s treatment says a red flag for a counterfeit drug is when it shows no results. He also says large discounts on drugs may indicate they are fake.

People pour in from across the country to Delhi for medical treatment.

In 2022, the national capital had nine Joint Commission International-accredited hospitals, meaning they meet global standards of clinical excellence. This is the highest number in the country, making Delhi a medical hub. This also brings with it the problem of counterfeit drugs.

Every month, Delhi Police and the Delhi Drugs Control Department report seizures of medicines they describe as “counterfeit, spurious, adulterated, illegally diverted or unauthorised”.

Substances seized range from basic allergy and skin treatment drugs to high-value cancer medicines, antibiotics, vaccines, and other life-saving pharmaceuticals.

Unless the operations are large, news of these raids and the names of the medicines seized seldom reach people. Tracing a fake medicine to a



The government should facilitate more sampling and have more testing labs. The onus can only be on the government to make these checks. It isn’t possible for individual hospitals to do actual quality checks

DR. SUMIT RAY
Medical Director,
Holy Family
Hospital, Delhi

person is a long and expensive process, so it is seldom done.

Medicine raids

In May this year, spurious oxytocin injections in government hospitals in Rajasthan’s Kota were a major reason for the deaths of five women following caesarean-section deliveries. The same batch of spurious oxytocin had reached Delhi government hospitals too, sources say, after which it was seized by the Drugs Control Department.

Five days after the inter-State drug raid that seized cancer medicines, the Crime Branch, in a separate investigation, arrested Dr. Manish Sharma, 39, a resident of Faridabad in Haryana, for allegedly selling smuggled, suspected adulterated, and counterfeit life-saving drugs.

According to the police, Sharma had gone to Russia to study medicine and returned to India in 2014. He later worked at a hospital in Faridabad before opening his own hospitals. After those ventures shut down, he and his wife started a polyclinic in the city. Sharma also registered HK Pharmaceuticals at the same address and began selling medicines on an e-commerce platform.

The police claim that he began sourcing medicines through illegal channels and selling them to buyers online. Last month, the Drugs Control Department seized counterfeit anti-rabies vaccine worth ₹2 lakh from Chandni Chowk’s Bhagirath Palace. A government official says the department acted on a tip-off and sent the vaccine to a testing centre in Himachal Pradesh’s Kasauli.

The problem of counterfeit drugs is not new. During the COVID-19 pandemic in 2021, the Crime Branch busted a facility allegedly manufacturing fake Remdesivir. At the time, hospitals were prescribing Remdesivir for COVID-19 and families were pooling savings to procure it, with one vial selling for as much as ₹90,000.

In 2022, spurious medicines valued at over ₹5 crore were seized from a factory at Tronica City in Uttar Pradesh’s Ghaziabad district. In 2024, investigators detected vials resembling high-value cancer drugs. Investigators are examining possible links between some of these and the present inter-State network, but no definitive connection has been established so far.

Labels stripped away

According to Crime Branch officials, medicines may reach people in different ways: counterfeit drugs made in warehouses, often made to look genuine; genuine medicines illegally diverted from the chain for which they were procured, such as drugs from a government hospital being diverted to the open market; and unauthorised medicines that are genuine but not legally approved or permitted for sale in India.

Once a medicine is tainted, either because it is spurious or has been removed from its legitimate supply chain, it moves through layers of intermediaries across States. Some are stored in homes or warehouses before being passed on to whole-

salers, brokers, and pharmacists.

Paperwork is another layer of camouflage. The police say invoices are generated for medicines that were never actually supplied, creating a paper trail for illicit transactions. In one instance, investigators found amounts routed through a firm’s bank account and, after GST and commission were deducted, the balance returned in cash. Registers and diaries recording medicine transactions and cash dealings were also recovered. The total turnover and profit from the illicit trade are still being worked out.

Medicines typically pass through manufacturers, clearing and forwarding agents, stockists, sub-stockists, and retailers before reaching a patient. Each handover creates an opportunity for pilferage, according to the police.

“Indian laws require purchase and sale records at every stage, but an invoice only attests that a transaction occurred; it does not ensure that the product inside the box matches its label,” says Nilaya Varma, Group CEO of Primus Partners. “That loophole is precisely where counterfeiters operate,” he adds.

Manufacturing and packaging can be particularly difficult to police, he says, because convincing labels, copied batch numbers, holograms, and reused original packaging can defeat visual inspection. At the wholesale level, multiple transfers can further blur a product’s source, allowing suspect stock to mix with genuine medicines. A pharmacist may be able to check the brand and batch number, but cannot establish the history of an individual pack.

Technology has added another layer of protection, but not an infallible one. India has required barcodes or QR codes on around 300 specified brands since August 2023, but a code that is merely scanned is not necessarily proof of provenance. “A copied or cloned code will pass a visual or app-based scan just as readily,” Varma says, arguing that verification against the manufacturer’s own database at the point of sale would provide a stronger safeguard.

The scale of the pharmaceutical market also limits the reach of testing. The Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation and State drug regulators tested 1,16,323 samples in 2024-25, of which 245 were declared spurious or adulterated.

According to the government, more than 960 drug manufacturing premises have undergone risk-based inspections, resulting in over 860 regulatory actions.

Varma says regulators cannot physically examine every pack moving through more than 8.5 lakh retail pharmacies. “Sampling is a backstop that identifies a bad batch after the fact,” he says. “It cannot certify the pack in a patient’s hand at the moment of sale.”

The Crime Branch is still tracing the complete downstream chain, including pharmacies, distributors, end beneficiaries, and the financial trail. The number of patients who may have received counterfeit medicines, and any confirmed adverse health consequences, has not yet been established.

The lowest bidder

The wider supply chain also raises questions about how medicines enter hospitals in the first place. Lower tendering costs are among the causes, say doctors in Delhi, particularly those working in government settings.

Hospitals have drug and therapeutics committees that select and regulate the medicines brought into the premises. They point out that government directives require medicines to be procured from the lowest bidder, and if a hospital has not done so, it is expected to explain why.

Dr. Sumit Ray, Medical Director of Holy Family Hospital in Okhla, Delhi, a hospital run by a charitable trust, says the committee he chairs decides which medicines are selected. “It is difficult to prevent such medicines from entering the system, but there can be multiple levels of checks. For instance, if it is a new pharmaceutical company, we check which other hospitals it has supplied to, who its manufacturers are, and what is



Deepali Dhingra

The family WhatsApp group was abuzz the other day with memories of Wenger's, the iconic Connaught Place bakery that recently completed a century in the capital. Gen X cousins fondly recalled frequenting the confectionery for its classic chocolate eclairs and pineapple pastries, while others chimed in with nostalgia for the shami kebabs and mutton patties.

Then, a voice from the younger end of the family piped up: "We still go, nothing can beat Wenger's. The cream roll is one of the best. Their patties and shami kebabs are also amazing. Gen Z also can't stop talking about it."

When I dropped in at the historic bakery on a weekday afternoon, I realised that the younger cousin was spot on. Passing beneath the signboard with Wenger's written in an elegant font, and glass and wood panels flanking the main door, one enters only to be engulfed in the unmistakable aroma of warm butter, melting chocolate, and freshly baked pastry crusts. Standing shoulder-to-shoulder at the glass counters are corporate executives in formal shirts and

Wenger's scores a century

As the iconic bakery turns 100, a look inside the institution where classic recipes, and old-school charm still rule

trousers grabbing a quick mid-day mutton patty, university students debating whether to split a rum ball or a cream roll, and elderly patrons patiently waiting for their box of pineapple pastries.

There is a fast-paced rhythm to the room. The staff behind the counters move with practised ease, packing white-and-red boxes. In an age where modern patisseries prioritise plush seating and aesthetic backdrops just right for the 'gram, Wenger's remains blissfully unpretentious with its strictly takeaway, classic ethos. You come, you order, you stand in the corridor outside to devour your warm patty or get cream on your

hands while licking the chocolate eclair, but you always leave with a grin on your face.

That stubborn commitment to quality and consistency is precisely how a Swiss bakery, established in 1926 by Mr and Mrs Wenger, survived a century of shifting tastes, political turns, and modern competition. Originally catering to British troops and Indian royalty, and later acquired by the Tandon family in the 1940s, Wenger's became part of the city's culinary DNA.

Today, it is run by cousins Atul Tandon and Aman Tandon, the third-generation flagbearers of the legacy, who look after the



Sweet memories (Clockwise from far left) Entrance of the Wenger's at Connaught Place; Charanjeet Singh, the 82-year-old manager; and the famous patties and confectioneries. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



production. And while classics such as the lemon tart, chocolate jap, French hearts and black forest continue to remain favourites, they have seamlessly integrated modern additions like macarons, mini baguette pizzas, and red velvet pastries into their line-up. The adjoining Wenger's Deli, which they started in 2013, serves a small selection of pastas, pizzas, hot dogs and smoothies.

Look back with nostalgia The distinguished-looking sardarji who can always be spotted at the bakery is Charanjeet Singh – the 82-year-old manager who joined Wenger's as a strapping young lad in 1965. Dressed impeccably in a full-sleeved blue shirt, dark grey trousers, dark blue tie and turban, he recalls how there were just four flavours of pastries sold at the confectionery. "There was vanilla,

strawberry, chocolate and pineapple. There was no concept of fresh cream or buttercream. We also sold gâteaux in vanilla, strawberry and pineapple which were for ₹3, and the chocolate ones sold for ₹4. Now, we make more than 40 types of cakes and 70 varieties of pastries and mousse," he says with a smile.

Over the years, Charanjeet has seen many first-timers become loyal customers and bring their children and grandchildren to introduce them to their favourite bakery. Interestingly, there are no sepia-tone framed photographs of the prominent dignitaries, politicians, film stars and cricketers who have dropped in over the decades, and become its loyal patrons. The former Chief Minister of Jammu and Kashmir, Farooq Abdullah, sarod maestro Amjad Ali Khan and his sons Ayaan Ali Bangash and Amaan Ali Bangash, artist MF Husain, who would famously scribble on their tissue papers, former Deputy Prime Minister of India LK Advani, former Prime Minister of India Morarji Desai and cricketer Gautam Gambhir have all walked through these glass doors. "Shah Rukh Khan used to visit during his television days. His favourites were the shami kebabs and lemon tarts," Charanjeet recalls.

Ask him how he feels about Wenger's hitting the 100-year mark and his eyes twinkle with pride. "There is no doubt about it; there is no confectionery, which has been so consistent with quality or has so much variety," he says.

As I leave after devouring a delicious, flaky mutton patty, coffee and a soft-as-a-cloud marzipan, Charanjeet Singh presses a small box of chocolates in my hand. "Don't say no; this is from all of us. Keep visiting," he says.

Perhaps this is why Wenger's has stood the test of time. Beyond the flawless quality and the century-old recipes, it is this unpretentious warmth that keeps Delhi coming back.

STEP OUT



Living traditions

Earthy Expressions brings together indigenous artists working across Gond, Bhil, patachitra, kalamkari, Kalighat, Saura and Warli traditions, exploring the links between Nature, cultural memory and community life. Curated by Kiran K Mohan, the exhibition looks at how inherited visual languages continue to evolve while remaining connected to environment, folklore and tradition. The works explore symbolism through distinct artistic practices. *It will be on view until October 31, 11am to 7pm, at Art Magnum, Yusuf Sarai.*



Inner landscapes

Memory and landscape come together in Bilanda – Walk Through Reminiscence, a solo exhibition by artist Ghazali Moinuddin. Bringing together Nature-inspired works, landscapes and personal recollections, the show reflects the artist's distinctive approach to texture and form. Moinuddin is known for creating his richly layered works using his fingers instead of brushes, giving the surfaces a tactile quality. *Presented by Artisrue, the exhibition runs until October 5, from 11am to 7pm, at Visual Arts Gallery, India Habitat Centre.*

Manav's calling

Actor and writer Manav Kaul talks about his travelogue *A Mountain, A Lake and A Song*

Mohammad Farhan

"He has the Midas touch" may well be an adage for the versatile Manav Kaul. Renowned for his slick acting in celebrated Bollywood films like *Badla*, *Thappad*, and *Jolly LLB 2*, Manav is equally masterful with the pen. When he dabbles in playwriting, he delivers immersive theatrical works, including *Ilhaam*, *Park*, and *Shakkar Ke Paanch Daane*. When he is not acting Manav Kaul can often be found in quaint cafés, channelling his creative energies into writing.

When approached for this interview about his travelogue *A Mountain, A Lake and A Song*, published by Penguin and translated from Hindi by Vaibhav Sharma, Manav responded with a congenial yes. He divulges a fascinating story about the genesis of this book, "I used to dream that one day I'd be writing a novel. But I didn't have the patience for it. I was writing short stories even when travelling from London to Paris, and from Paris to Chamonix."

I ask if his travelogue emanates the fragrance of fictionality, because he draws an alluring ambiguity between reality and imagination in it. Manav says, "I always find fiction more honest and something that holds more truth than truth itself. I realised late in life that I have a way of making things more interesting through writing." For him, writing is a refuge from the banality of life.

Manav believes that we are



governed by the desire "to know ourselves by stepping into the unknown".

And this book, plausibly his tapestry of the unknown, emerged from his travel experiences. "I took a step into the unknown when I started travelling without

even thinking where I was going. On every page I'm brutally honest about what I was feeling. I want to understand what happens when you have no comfort of language, home or your own people," he says. Manav is always willing to

moor himself around the mountains; so his travelogue resonates with his exploration of mountains from Mont Blanc in Europe to those in Binsar in Uttarakhand. And he calls himself "a mountain person".

Manav says, "I think if you have a mountain in front of you, you can look at it in the morning, afternoon, evening and night. Every time, it's going to give you something different. And that is the beauty of it."



Savouring Rajasthan (Left) Documenting a home-style Rajasthani thali; (below) babool ki paatdi ki sabji. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Flavours of the past

The Food Culture Yatra travels across India documenting disappearing food traditions. And, its findings reveal that it is not just recipes that are at risk

Teja Lele

The bread is born from embers. In parts of Mewar, Bhil women still bake maize bread over burning corn cobs, the dough wrapped in palash leaves, the maize grown from seeds saved within the family for generations.

There is no written recipe, or cookbook. The women who make it learned the way their mothers did: standing, watching, helping. It is exactly the kind of food the Food Culture Yatra hopes to document before it disappears.

The year-long project, led by The Kindness Meal, is travelling through Rajasthan, Karnataka, West Bengal, Gujarat and Assam, recording food traditions that have rarely made it onto paper. Backed by the French Embassy in India as part of the India-France Year of Innovation 2026, it brings together home cooks, farmers, artisans and local communities, building what founder Dipali Khandelwal calls a

"people's archive of India's food cultures". Along the way, the project's purpose shifted. "Many times we realised we weren't documenting recipes anymore," Dipali says. "The recipes almost became incidental. The real archive is the lived human wisdom underneath them."

Beyond the plate

That became clear during a visit to a Raika family near Ahore in western Rajasthan. The Raikas, pastoral nomads, walk long distances with their livestock and return home only with the monsoon. Dipali found out that even the simplest meals moved with the community, shaped by distance and season.

Curious, she asked an elderly Raika man what he thought about on those long walks. "Why think?" he asked. "Thinking is a disease of city people. A bird sings, and you listen. A flower blooms, and you enjoy the fragrance. A tree fruits, and you eat. What is there to think about?"

That answer changed the questions Dipali asks now. Instead of starting with recipes, she starts with seasons, trees, harvests, landscapes. The food follows on its own. Dipali soon realised that traditional food reveals a community's relationship with its land. The Yatra began in Jaisalmer, and she assumed the desert was defined by scarcity. She learnt differently. Communities across the Thar have spent generations working with plants most outsiders would overlook: tumba, a wild bitter melon; lana, a hardy desert shrub; bhurant, a resilient grass.



It's not that the recipe is disappearing tomorrow. It's that the one person who still knows it is growing older, and nobody's sitting beside them to learn

DIPALI KHADELWAL
Founder, The Kindness Meal

"That's generations of applied botany, water and risk management, quietly disguised as food," she says.

The story changed near Udaipur where tribal families cook over the embers of leftover corn cobs, forage in nearby forests, and wait out the brief weeks when mahua and jamun appear. The dishes change with the land.

In North Karnataka, Sahaja Samruddha, a grassroots organisation working with farmers, showed how everyday staples like ragi, jowar, tamarind, and coconut are part of daily food traditions. The organisation has also turned farmers' ecological knowledge into livelihoods: a women-run dal processing mill, initiatives that turn agricultural waste into craft.

Across communities, nobody worries that a specific recipe will vanish. What worries them is the knowledge around it. "It's not that the recipe is disappearing tomorrow," she says. "It's that the one person who still knows it is growing older, and nobody's sitting beside them to learn."

Restaurants and chefs are noticing too. At Sarvato, the restaurant inside Jaipur's City Palace and now part of the Relais & Châteaux network, that work starts in villages, not in the kitchen.

Documentation has become part of the cooking at Sarvato. The kitchen looks past Rajasthan's royal repertoire to the food of pastoral communities, farming families, and desert settlements.

The harder challenge is convincing communities their everyday food is worth documenting at all.

She has noticed villagers often dismiss their own food as ordinary. It takes longer conversations before stories of forgotten grains, seasonal greens and family techniques surface.

The journey has changed how Dipali thinks about disappearing food altogether. She has met women running seed banks and communities restoring old water systems. "I went in thinking I'd learn about food cultures," she says. "Instead I'm learning about the real world."



Other than outrage

Restrictions on women cannot be the answer to unsafe public spaces

There is a sickening sense of *dējā vu* in last month's headlines of sexual assaults against women and children. In the national capital alone, the gang-rape of a 17-year-old girl in Astha Kunj Park by three men posing as police personnel, the gang-rape and murder of a 16-year-old in Swaroop Nagar, and the gang-rape of another 17-year old on a sleeper bus travelling from Greater Noida to Delhi have each shocked the nation briefly before giving way to a numb outrage. Little seems to have changed in the 14 years since the candlelight marches and commissions after the Nirbhaya case unleashed a slew of new schemes, laws and funds that vowed to protect women and girls from sexual violence, especially in public spaces. The latest report of the National Crime Records Bureau shows an 80% surge in crimes against women since Nirbhaya, from 2.4 lakh in 2012 to 4.4 lakh in 2024. Some of this can be attributed to higher reporting of crimes, facilitated by those new laws and schemes, but that is not sufficient to account for the vast number of them. In 2024, more than 50 crimes against women were reported every hour, with the highest rate of such crimes seen in the metro cities of Jaipur, Indore, Lucknow, and Delhi.

The government has listed a slew of initiatives meant to deal with the problem, from the Safe City project to Mission Shakti, from a women's helpline and emergency response support system to one-stop centres for survivors of sexual violence and fast-track courts, many of which have been financed through the Nirbhaya Fund. The recent crimes, however, put a question mark on the implementation of such schemes. A safe city cannot be created simply by installing lighting and CCTV cameras, if they are not functional, monitored, and connected to a response system. Police patrols and emergency numbers matter only if they result in prompt intervention from trained and sensitised personnel. It is important to move from scheme-based policing to preventive, and outcome-based policing, with public audits of vulnerable locations with deadlines and accountability to rectify deficiencies. The justice system must address the enormous backlog of cases; the promise of speedy investigation loses meaning if survivors spend years awaiting trial. The authorities must also resist the temptation to convert women's safety into restrictions on women's freedom. The answer to unsafe public spaces cannot be that women should avoid parks after dark, return home earlier, travel only with companions, or otherwise organise their lives around the possibility of male violence. Most importantly, there is a need to challenge the culture of sexual violence and toxic masculinity, enabled by age-old patriarchal traditions.

Season's end

The IMD is conservative when it comes to projecting rainfall deficit

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) issues two forecasts – in April and May – before the monsoon. Both unambiguously pointed to a dry monsoon – confidence boosted by global unanimity that one of the strongest El Niño ever was in the offing – and the consequential question was, ‘How bad?’ It turns out that the IMD's forecast of ‘below normal’ rain (90% to 95% of average) was conservative. This was surprising, given that its models pointed to ‘deficient’ rains (below 90%). On September 30, when India's monsoon tally ended, the IMD announced 759 mm across the country, 87% of the normal 869 mm. El Niño years, when the Central Equatorial Pacific warms and suppresses monsoon rains, test a weather department's mettle because predicting the extent of the shortfall is challenging. It is perplexing why the agency opted for ‘below normal’ rainfall when it could have warned of a ‘deficiency’ and claimed accuracy. As of now the IMD can only claim technical victory because the final number sits within the 4%-5% error window. However, at a disaggregated level, the IMD's struggle with getting magnitude right is far more glaring. June got 65% of its normal, far drier than the 92% forecast. July, expected to be below 94%, ended up with 1% point more rain. August came in at 84% of the LPA, in line with the “below 94%” forecast. September at 92.4% finished a little above the forecast of ‘below 91%.’ The IMD expected a ‘normal’ monsoon in the northeast, which then recorded its driest since 1901, or 26% short. The south peninsula ran 23% short. central and north-west India – tipped to fall below normal – finished close to predictions, driven by ocean conditions and Western disturbances.

Climate change makes this more complicated. Western disturbances, extra-tropical rain-bearing systems, have been bringing more rain to India in the monsoon months, while southern India seems more vulnerable to El Niño-triggered volatility. This is reflected in *kharif* sowing. On July 10, *kharif* sowing trailed last year's by 16%; by early September the gap had narrowed to under 2%. Karnataka has declared drought in well over a 100 taluks and Maharashtra in 265 of 358, though the national deficit of about 12% is below the Centre's 20% threshold for an ‘agricultural drought.’ The IMD expects El Niño to strengthen and bring below normal rain over most of the country from October to December, threatening soil moisture and reservoir recharge. The Cabinet has lifted wheat's support price by ₹25 a quintal and mustard's by ₹413, nudging diversification. Given the consequences of IMD's forecasts, it should improve its sub-regional forecast systems and not shy from being the bearer of ill-news, if needed.

A compilation of articles, on the Editorial and Opinion pages, offering insights into the Mahatma's ideas and legacy

Gandhiji's many ways of understanding 'genius'



Gopalkrishna Gandhi

A teacher who has held administrative, diplomatic and constitutional positions

This column is not about Gandhi as a genius (which, with a laugh, he would say he certainly was not) or about the spectacularly original man I believe him to have been. It is about the place of the word ‘genius’ in Gandhi's thought and in his writings.

Why should that common word be picked up from Gandhi's teeming English vocabulary for special attention? Because his use of that valuational word tells us a great deal about his assessment of persons and situations – a matter of interest in itself. And also because we can apply (or not apply) his yardsticks for evaluating persons and happenings in our contemporary times.

There is another non-Gandhi reason as well. Most users of the word do not know that ‘genius’ is a Latin word. Not just a word of Latin origin but a Latin word in its totality – in the way it is spelt, pronounced and meant. English has borrowed ‘genius’ from the language of Virgil, Horace, Ovid without any change whatsoever, somewhat like how C.V. Raman describes the journey of the diamond from its womb under the earth to human hands ‘...absolutely fresh...perfect from nature's crucible.’ And so, reflecting on the word, one might also ponder its travel from one language register to another, admitting some variations in its action.

Here are representative examples culled by Gandhi-researcher Murtaza Gandhi from *The Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi* (CWMG). Pronounced in both Latin and English identically, as Jee-nee-us, its meaning in classical Latin is ‘divine inner power’. In modern English, when used as a noun, for example ‘the genius S. Ramanujan...’, it denotes a person with exceptional intellectual or creative ability. When used as an adjective, for example, ‘the genius of India...’, it refers to a singular or unique characteristic.

The first encounter

Gandhi uses the word in both senses. His first recorded use of it is as in a skill, a vision, an act of sheer dare. He talks about it as an achievement, not as the description of a person. The reference goes back to 1888, when he was 19 years old and when his English was unpolished. Travelling by the liner *S.S. Clyde* from Bombay to England to start his law studies, he was taken up by the sight of the Suez Canal. Cutting the slender isthmus of the Suez between Asia and Africa to save on journey time by several days, it was a marvel to behold.

He writes in what is now known as his London Diary: “The construction of the Suez Canal I am

not able to understand. It is indeed marvellous. I cannot think of the genius of a man who invented it. I don't know how he would have done it.” (CWMG, Vol.01, p.11). The ‘man who invented it’ is, of course, Ferdinand de Lesseps (1805-1894), a French diplomat and entrepreneur, who thought of and made the Canal with the help of two engineers – the Austrian Alois Negrelli and fellow Frenchman Linant de Bellefond.

In this year, 2026, which marks the 70th anniversary of the 1956 Anglo-French-Israeli bombardment of Egypt which aimed to take over the Suez Canal – which Egypt's President Gamal Abdel Nasser had nationalised, – Israel is using more lethal bombs with prodigal abandon in Palestine and Gaza and, with the United States joining the fire-play over Iran, causing the death, among others, of the Supreme Leader of the Iranian state, no less. So, today, we can reflect on Gandhi's marvelling at the genius that went into the making of that oceanic passageway only with anxiety for the future of the area around that marvel.

The dark side

This brings one to a phrase which is twinned to ‘genius’: evil genius (or malignum genium). The earliest known use of that phrase as a concept is in French philosopher Rene Descartes' use of it in his 1641 opus *Meditations on First Philosophy*. He posits in it the existence of a power that is the very opposite of the divine power that actuates ‘genius’ – evil genius, a malignant God or evil power.

By 1893, Barrister M.K. Gandhi was in South Africa and soon became the spokesman and leader of the Indian community there in its strivings for the recognition of its rights and its dignity. Stung by the discriminations and humiliations that Indian South Africans were subjected to, particularly at the hands of the Asiatic Department, we see him use the word not just in its simple sense of a compliment but in its contrary avatar: “There seems to be somewhere in the Asiatic Department of the government an evil genius working through it.” (CWMG, Vol.04, p.26, 23. The Bazaars in The Transvaal) .

‘Evil genius’ occurs in Gandhi's vocabulary again when he is back in India, where he uses it in the context of the Jallianwala Bagh massacre (April 13, 1919) but very pointedly for an individual: “General Dyer has been haltingly blamed, and his evil genius, Sir Michael O'Dwyer, entirely exonerated...” (CWMG, Vol.19, p.339). Just stopping short of using the phrase ‘evil genius’, he invokes the word witheringly with sarcasm, to

The word ‘genius’ offers a window into the Mahatma's assessment of people and events

describe the British Raj's policy of ‘Divide and Rule’: “But just now I am speaking of the genius of the Government. It has not hesitated to divide Hindus from Muslims in order to be able to retain its hold on us.” (CWMG, Vol.19, p.398, Speech at Nankana Saheb – March 3, 1921).

As a term of praise

The earliest recorded reference by him of a person as a genius in a wholly complimentary sense, is for Lokamanya Bal Gangadhar Tilak who, in 1916, in the town of Belgaum, famously declared (in Marathi) “Swaraj is my birthright and I shall have it.” The ‘Father of Indian Unrest’ had been dead four years but addressing the Indian National Congress' session in the same town of Belgaum in December 1924 as Congress President, Gandhi could not but refer to him and said (in English): He was the genius of swaraj (CWMG, Vol.25, p.508, Concluding Speech at Belgaum Congress, December 27, 1924). Gandhi is doing something very interesting here. He is terming Tilak as a genius of and in something very singular, very specific – swaraj. He is using the term very precisely, very contextually, like he would be if he were to describe Einstein as a genius of the Theory of Relativity.

The next most notable use by him of the word as a personal tribute is for Rabindranath Tagore. Speaking on him in 1931, Gandhi says: “In common with thousands of his countrymen I owe much to one who by his poetic genius and singular purity of life has raised India in the estimation of the world.” (CWMG, Vol.45, p.125, Tribute to Rabindranath Tagore – January 26, 1931).

He was to use the word for him again but again, not as a direct adjective but with a value added: “His creative genius has also given us Santiniketan, Sriniketan and Visvabharati” (CWMG, Vol.84, p.124, Speech at Prayer Meeting, May 8, 1946).

There is one person for whom Gandhi uses the word ‘genius’ without any niche that encases ‘genius’. It is for his friend and almost-preceptor, the young Bombay-based jeweller, poet, Jaina ascetic Rajchandra or Raychandbhai as Gandhi called him: “Kavi Rajchandra was born in a place called Vavania in Kathiawar... His schooling was quite elementary. But he was a genius. He knew Sanskrit, Magadhi and, I believe, Pali” (CWMG, Vol.43, p.98, A Great Seer – March 18, 1930).

Genius can do marvels and do evil. Remembering Gandhi's awareness of that truth is today not a matter of language alone but of life and death.

The Mahatma's unfinished work on the world stage

Writing about Gandhiji's death on his birthday may not be an entirely odd thing, given how he died and how that conflicted with what he stood for. In popular perception, Gandhiji was a tired, old man whose life's work was over when he was assassinated.

In any case, the people he sought to train and transform into compassionate human beings had turned bigoted murderers or condoned bigotry and mass murder during Partition. The last eccentric, going-against-the-grain act they allowed him was fasting in favour of Pakistan. Revisionist history of today seeks to downgrade his role in India's freedom by counterposing Netaji.

But it can be argued that Gandhiji's best years were yet to come even if India had failed him then and now. At 78, Gandhiji was healthy enough to have gone on a village-to-village walk in Noakhali, fasted for three days in Calcutta to stop the rioting before the five-day Delhi fast, and talked about a fast-unto-death to stop the killing of Muslims in Bihar. His health may well have facilitated his shining on the world stage for several more years.

The emergence of a global image

Gandhiji had already ascended the world stage a few decades before in-part due to the rapid growth of print media in the first half 20th century that sought out new and novel stories. Among a non-violent campaign's advantages were that it was carried out in the public domain, transparently – far easier to cover than a clandestine plot. A report on the Dharasana beatings ran in some 1,300 papers worldwide. And photos of Gandhiji, with his dress, or the lack of it, quirks and eccentricities, looked great on newsprint.

Among the many influences Gandhiji had globally was the Black civil rights movement. In America, African-American newspapers were only eager to see parallels and seek inspiration. And it was not symbolic or philosophical but direct and tactical, too. A Harlem ashram and an Ohio ahimsa farm sprang up. Even the



M. Kalyanaraman

Had the Mahatma lived, his message of non-violence might have travelled further and shaped global movements

goat-milking transmuted to America.

Martin Luther King may have been the most famous of civil rights leaders' visits to India but there were many other organisers such as Bayard Rustin and James Lawson who had immersive sojourns in India. A report in *The Hindu* quotes Rustin – he was the organiser of the 1963 March on Washington, at which King delivered the “I Have a Dream” speech – as saying in 1948 that the “Indian non-violent revolution has much to teach us”.

During the Montgomery Bus Boycott, described as the practical kick-off of the civil rights protests led by King, Rustin put his learnings to successful use. He insisted that Montgomery should only be one of many such sites. He ticked off King for having armed guards in his house, saying that Gandhiji would not do that. In a move that caught the attention of many, but which Rustin owed to Gandhiji's methods, he asked that the leaders should go and voluntarily surrender to the police, saying that, yes, they had broken the law, but that it was the right thing to do. Lawson set up a Satyagraha training school in Nashville.

Non-violence on a global scale

Gandhiji did become a global icon, posthumously. For sure, his methods drew from the past. A peaceful march organised by a priest in St. Petersburg was violently put down by the Tsar although it triggered the 1905 revolution. But what was new was that Gandhiji showed that they were duplicable on a mass scale in an organised manner. This was the novelty that caught the imagination of the world later.

Scholars have shown that in the latter half of 20th century, when asymmetries of power solidified, only non-violent campaigns could succeed and did so. East Timor was a sterling example.

Perhaps the best chance that the Palestinians had for Swaraj was in the initial stages of the Intifada. Though known more for the

stone-throwing, the initial protests were largely non-violent but forceful in a Gandhian way. More than all the bombings, assassinations and the plane hijacks engineered by the Palestinians, it could be argued that Intifada 1 forced the Israeli leadership to negotiate and at least on paper commit to a two-state solution eventually though subsequent events upended all that.

It would seem that Gandhiji had planned on playing an active global role after India's Independence. A report in *The Hindu* on March 9, 1948, quotes Horace Alexander as saying that Gandhiji, in England in 1931, had told his friends that when India would be free, he would take part in a world movement for spreading the gospel of non-violence. Another report in August 1947 says that “discussions are now going on between Mahatma Gandhi and some of his American, Indian and European friends” for the world conference.

The conference was held in 1949, a year after his death. International participants discussed setting up an organisation. A.J. Muste wanted to set up a training institute in India. But, without the man himself, Gandhiji became only a soul force, not a physical presence, for non-violent activists across the world.

The Palestine test

If idle speculation could be allowed, a living Gandhiji would have electrified the world that had just gone through a monstrous war and the Holocaust. Instead of becoming just a memorial possibility and vague idealism, non-violence and compassion would have been far more rooted in global discourse.

The best test for Gandhiji would have been Palestine.

If he could make an Englishman ashamed of himself, could he not have made Israeli Jews ashamed of inflicting on Palestinians the suffering Jews had endured for centuries?

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LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A balance The new NCERT Class 9 Social Science curriculum significantly reduces the space given to modern European history, replacing chapters on the French and Russian Revolutions. At the same time, it places a much-needed emphasis on Indian history, exploring traditions of governance,	sacred responsibility, and regional resistance and resilience. The inclusion of the <i>Sengol</i> provides an opportunity for students to learn about India's civilisational continuity and political traditions. Since the historical interpretation of the <i>Sengol</i> remains contested (inside pages, October 1), it is vital that	textbooks present competing accounts with adequate evidence. In an age shaped by global change, our education system must seamlessly combine cultural rootedness with rigorous historical inquiry and critical thinking. Sathiyapriya Kumar, Thirukkattupalli, Tamil Nadu	Numbers must work In my experience, several official telephone numbers published on the Tamil Nadu government websites are either ‘switched off, not reachable, or remain unanswered’. These numbers are provided specifically to enable citizens to contact the government offices	concerned for information, clarification or assistance. The official CM Helpline information states that citizens should be able to access grievance services without having to visit a grievance centre and provides multiple channels, including telephone, online portal, mobile application and email to <i>Mudhalvarin</i>	<i>Mugavari</i>. Therefore, there appears to be a clear disconnect between the citizen-friendly services announced by the government and the actual accessibility. Balamarthandan D., Chennai Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.
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Should the EC take action against those filing forms for mass deletions?



Ashok Lavasa
Former Election Commissioner



Prasenjit Bose
Congress leader and petitioner in West Bengal SIR case in Supreme Court

PARLEY

As Phase 3 of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls unfolds, a surge in Form 7 applications, the mechanism for seeking deletion of names, in Karnataka has raised concerns. More than 4,000 such forms were filed in the State, with 1,363 in one place coming from just 10 electors, many reportedly targeting Muslim names. Uttarakhand has seen objections filed in an Electoral Registration Officer's (ERO) name without his knowledge, while in West Bengal, data shows that nearly 90% of Form 7 applications were accepted. Similar cases have been reported by *The Hindu* from Rajasthan and Gujarat as well. Should the Election Commission (EC) take action against those filing forms for mass deletions? Ashok Lavasa and Prasenjit Bose discuss the question in a conversation moderated by **Sreeparna Chakrabarty**. Edited excerpts:

What is the ERO legally required to do when a Form 7 arrives?

Ashok Lavasa: Under the Registration of Electors Rule 1960, all the steps that are required for registration, for deletion, and for amendment are listed. Form 7 applications are typically used to object to the entry of a person in the electoral roll. As soon as a Form 7 notice is received by the ERO, the Rules prescribe that first of all they should be put on the notice board for the public to know that objections have been received against such and such person. After this, a specific notice is to be given to the person against whom a complaint has been received. The Rules provide that in case an inquiry is demanded, the ERO or the officer designated cannot take a decision on his own without conducting a formal inquiry in which he can even summon the complainant and the person against whom the complaint has been received. He can ask the complainant to testify under oath that the particulars that he is presenting and the documents that he is giving are true. He is also informed that in case this is found incorrect, there is a penalty under Section 31 of the Representation of the People Act (RPA) for which he can be penalised with imprisonment for giving false information. This is the procedure. The spirit behind this is that no name should be deleted without giving adequate opportunity to the person against whom a complaint has been received.

How do these bulk forms emerge and is there a limit on how many objections one person can file? Also, can Section 31 of the RPA, which penalises false declarations, be



Karnataka CM D.K. Shivakumar staged a sit-in protest demanding an inquiry into alleged voter list deletions through bulk Form 7 submissions, outside the office of the Chief Electoral Officer in Bengaluru, on Thursday. PTI

invoked if somebody files bulk Form 7s?

AL: I think the EC has issued instructions from time to time; it is not given in the Rules as such. But instructions have been given that you should not receive more than, I think, five or six forms according to current norms. With respect to Section 31, I don't think it can be invoked. It is specifically to do with giving false information.

In Karnataka's Babaleshwar, 1,363 of Form 7 applications came from just 10 electors. Reports have said that many of the deletions targeted Muslim names.

AL: Clearly, this is a misuse of the procedure. The concerned authorities need to act against people who are misusing the system. You would recall that in Karnataka last year, when the Leader of Opposition had given some instances, the EC had itself clarified that out of some 2,000 odd applications that it received, only roughly 28 had been found to be correct. The question here is that we still do not know whether the EC has proceeded against somebody for making a false declaration. This penal provision, to the best of my knowledge, has hardly been used against anyone. And unless there is a deterrence, this provision will lose its efficacy.

West Bengal has seen one of the highest rates of acceptance of Form 7s. What is the petition against this in the SC about?

Prasenjit Bose: There are specific formats in which aggregated data on all Forms – 6, 7 and 8 – have to be recorded and disclosed at the end of any revision period by the EC. But that has not been followed in most States, especially in West Bengal. So, we had to request for the disclosure of that data because we found anomalies in the data that were disclosed during the claims and objections period.



There are specific formats in which aggregated data on all Forms – 6, 7 and 8 – have to be recorded and disclosed at the end of any revision period by the EC. But that has not been followed in most States, especially in West Bengal

PRASENJIT BOSE

As per the facts revealed by the affidavit filed by the EC in response to the petition that we had filed, the total Form 6 applications for inclusion were 34 lakh, out of which 7,26,000 were rejected. As far as Form 7 is concerned, the total number received was 6,39,000, which by itself, if you compare with States of similar sizes such as Bihar or Tamil Nadu, is on the higher side. And out of the 6,39,000 Form 7 applications received, 5,72,000 were accepted. So, you have an almost 90% rate of acceptance of Form 7 and less than 21% for Form 6. This anomaly is quite glaring. The problem lies in the deterrence mechanism of Section 31 of the RPA.

In many cases, the person in whose name the forms were filed denied having knowledge of the same. Is there some central mechanism which can be used to file forms?

PB: I will give you the latest example from Uttarakhand. I have on record, the ERO of Haridwar Rural constituency confirming that he has not submitted any Form 7 filed in his name. In one constituency, 3,500 Form 7 applications were submitted just hours before the window of claims and objections were about to get over and all the objections were in the name of the ERO. It has been done in an automated manner.

A similar mechanism was used in West Bengal vis-a-vis the appellate tribunals where automated appeals for exclusion have been filed which one of the Election Commissioners had flagged. Judicial intervention is needed to stop this as these illegalities are depriving genuine electors from their right to vote.

AL: This is quite absurd and calls for a probe. Clearly, the ERO cannot file objections. Although in the Rules there is a provision that the ERO can make some corrections on his own, that does not amount to filing so many objections. And it is the responsibility of the Chief Electoral Officer of the State and the EC to thoroughly investigate this matter. However, just because applications are filed, we should not condemn the system. I think we need to actually hold the system accountable. As far as the centralisation of data or

generating objections in a centralised fashion is concerned, I think we are speculating. There is no evidence of that. But, we do know that one of the Election Commissioners has actually red-flagged the issue saying that it creates the possibility of manipulation at the central level.

What can be done to deter this?

AL: I think there are some safeguards in place, but the point is whether they are being enforced. The EC generally after filing FIRs is not following them up systematically because it is presumed that now this is the responsibility of the concerned law enforcement machinery. This is where the EC needs to put in place a very strong monitoring mechanism. Earlier, I have suggested that the National Crime Records Bureau must have a separate data set on election-related crimes. And they should be reported separately so that all these figures are in the public domain. Once this data is in the public domain, people will analyse and flag these issues. The EC also has certain internal norms such as if in any polling booth, there are more than 2% additions or deletions, that particular booth is taken up for greater scrutiny. In all these instances where we are saying that 2,000 or more applications were received, the point is whether the system is accepting them. Is it actually leading to unjustified removal or addition? And finally, whether the system is taking note of the possibility of misuse.

PB: My point is that if the institution itself which is supposed to uphold the law and administer it, if at least a section within that institution starts violating the law, then the entire system breaks down. I think that is what has happened. In terms of reform, what has happened is that the electoral laws, RPA Act and especially these Forms were framed at a time in the 1950s and 60s. It was a non-digital era. Today we have digital databases and online submission of Forms. I think our laws have become out of sync with the way the process is being conducted today. There is a need for legal reforms.

AL: If people are committing fraud that obviously cannot be dealt with under the RPA. This is a weak link in the system; our law-and-order machinery is not taking these cases seriously. That is why I suggested there has to be a specific monitoring mechanism for electoral offences.



To listen to the full interview
Scan the code or go to the link
www.thehindu.com

A reflection on two songs and their nationalisms

While it is customary to garland Gandhiji on his birthday, this year, let us listen to him instead and to the song he lived by. At a time when the Republic has spent 10 months legislating about another song, the contrast will be a lesson in what nationalism is, and what it is not.

The song the Republic legislated about is *Vande Mataram*. In January 2026, the Union Home Ministry directed that all six stanzas of the National Song be performed at official functions, with everyone standing at attention. In July, a second order made the six-stanza text the “official version” and placed the Song before the Anthem.

Parliament amended the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971, to bring the National Song within the ambit of criminal law for the first time. To intentionally prevent its singing, or to disturb an assembly engaged in singing it, now invites imprisonment of up to three years.

On September 22, the Supreme Court heard the Carnatic musician and author, T.M. Krishna's challenge to the law and the orders. It did not decide the case. It asked the Union government to reply. However, Justice Joymalya Bagchi said that while the state may decide whether the Song has two stanzas or six, *Bijoe Emmanuel* (the SC judgment which upholds the right to religious freedom, constitutional tolerance and silent objection) still governs. A conscientious objector, to one stanza or all, should face no criminal consequences if she/he respectfully stood but didn't sing. Justice Bagchi's view is not yet a judgment but one wishes it should be.

The same morning, the Solicitor General answered the plea for national consensus by stating that law-making cannot follow the ideas of Naxalites. This author, in court for another matter, rose to say that to think, is not to be a Naxalite.

The episode matters only because it sums up the two nationalisms discussed here: one answers an



Sanjay Hegde
Senior Advocate of the Supreme Court of India

We have a National Anthem, protected by law, and a National Song, honoured by usage. Let the Republic recognise *Vaishnava Janato* as our National Prayer

argument, the other renames the arguer.

Vande Mataram

Let us take a closer look at the six stanzas of the Song: Bankim Chandra Chatterjee wrote the first two around 1875, reportedly as a filler for his journal. They are a hymn to a landscape, richly watered, bountiful, and cool with southern breezes. Any Indian of any faith can sing these stanzas about her nation.

The later stanzas came with his novel *Anandamath*, and they name names. The motherland becomes Durga with her 10 weapons, Lakshmi, and Saraswati. It is two songs stitched together, and the divide has run through our politics since 1905, when the Partition of Bengal made its opening words the war cry of *Swadeshi*.

The freedom movement resolved the problem sharply. In October 1937, on a resolution moved by Rajendra Prasad and seconded by Vallabhbhai Patel, the Congress Working Committee acknowledged the validity of Muslim and others' objections to the later stanzas and adopted the first two alone for national gatherings.

Rabindranath Tagore, who had first set the song to music, blessed the change. He loved the opening stanzas and disowned the theology that followed.

On January 24, 1950, India's first President Rajendra Prasad announced that *Jana Gana Mana* would be the National Anthem and that *Vande Mataram* would be “honoured equally”. Honour is not an obligation and for 55 years, the law protected the Flag, the Constitution and the Anthem, and deliberately left the Song outside the penal net. Love for the song was invited and obedience was never demanded.

Nor was the two-stanza settlement any insult to Bankim. The Bhagavad Gita is seven hundred verses from a Mahabharata of a

hundred thousand. Our national anthem is the first of Tagore's five stanzas. Fitting a work to a public purpose is homage and not a denigration.

This settlement worked. In 1997, A.R. Rahman, born a Hindu and a convert to Islam, reimagined *Vande Mataram* as *Maa Tujhe Salaam*. Ask anyone under 40 to sing *Vande Mataram* and you will hear Rahman.

It is this settlement of 1937, of 1950, and of 1997 that the current orders and statutes have reopened, and that the Supreme Court has now, rightly, handed back to the state and to us.

The other song

Five centuries before Bankim, Narsinh Mehta of Junagadh was excommunicated by his own caste for singing among

‘untouchables’. He composed *Vaishnava jana to tene kahiye, je peed parai jaane re* (Call that one alone a man of God, who knows another's pain as his own). The song has no map, no enemy, no throne. It audits a human being: one who serves without pride, bows to all and disparages none, keeps word, deed and thought in one line, looks on all with an equal eye, tells no lie, touches no wealth that is not his, honours every woman, and has put away deceit, lust and anger.

Read that against the Constitution and you will find that Narsinh drafted a version of the Preamble early and set it to music.

Feeling another's pain is fraternity assuring the dignity of the individual. Bowing to all is Article 14. The equal eye is our secularism and the hand that refuses another's wealth is the law of probity. The tongue that will not lie is the informed citizen of Article 51A.

Gandhi carried it from Sabarmati to his last prayer meeting, beside the Koran and Christian hymns, and in a hundred years no one has felt excluded by it.

Vande Mataram tests your posture; *Vaishnava Janato* tests your

conduct.

Here, then, are two songs and two nationalisms. One venerates the soil and asks the citizen to bow. The other civilises the soul and asks citizens to be worthy. One now comes with a sub-inspector attached. The other has never needed one.

A modest proposal

So, on Gandhi Jayanti, here's a proposal. We have a National Anthem, protected by law, and a National Song, honoured by usage. Let the Republic recognise *Vaishnava Janato* as our National Prayer, through the gentle method used in 1950, and not the muscular method of 2026. No order, no penalty, no compulsory standing. Only recognition and no mandatory requirement. Let it be sung, by those who wish, where the National Song is sung.

Let schoolchildren learn its meaning in every language. A prayer compelled is no prayer at all. That is the point.

Bankim's third stanza counted “*sapta koti kantha*” – the seven crore throats from his motherland, an undivided Bengal. In 1905, Sarala Devi sang it as thirty crore, and the motherland became India. Today we are 140 crore, and every crore was added by inclusion; none by compulsion.

A choir of 1.4 billion cannot be conducted with a *lathi* (stick). In a symphony that size, the conductor's only instrument is the willingness of the singers, won by making everyone feel the song is theirs. Inclusion is not a concession to the fastidious. It is the better tune.

The Constitution does not demand that we all worship the same way. It demands that we remain, all 140 crore of us, equal citizens. We are better off not insisting that everyone sing our song, and instead praying that everyone becomes a *Vaishnava jana* in citizenship.

Standing at attention takes 90 seconds. Feeling *peed parai* (pain of others) takes a lifetime and it, not the standing, is what builds a nation.

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO OCTOBER 2, 1976

New watches with Swiss assistance

As there was no issue dated October 2, 1976 from the issue dated October 1, 1976

New Delhi, September 30: A Horological Institute is likely to be set up in India with Swiss assistance for training Indian personnel in the highly sophisticated technology of watch-making to meet the vast domestic demand which is expected to reach ten million pieces a year by 1980.

A Swiss delegation is arriving shortly for follow up discussions on a phased programme for importing components and assembling them in India during the first stage, obtaining machinery for making these components and finally making the machines in India itself for achieving near self-sufficiency both in design and production for keeping pace with the rapid technological advances in the industry.

The HMT, which has already acquired the necessary expertise in watch manufacture with Japanese collaboration will be able to complete this three-phase programme in the next few years if an agreement is reached with the Swiss industry soon. A high-power Indian delegation visited Switzerland for preliminary discussions.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO OCTOBER 2, 1926

The Madras Monegar choultry

The following appeal has been issued by the Board of Directors of the above Choultry:—

The object of this charitable institution founded in the year 1782 to provide for the living of those who had been thrown in distress on account of the disastrous results of the invasions of Hyder Ali from Mysore, and latterly of old and helpless persons who had no other means of subsistence, is well-known to the public.

This laudable object was accomplished without interruption, but owing to the crippled financial condition of this humanitarian institution, the number of paupers who were receiving shelter and support therein have had to be considerably reduced with the result that while there is accommodation for 140 persons, only 80 men and women can at present be supported by it.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Decline in Apple production so far this year in Himachal

48 in per cent. Apple production in Himachal Pradesh has dropped 48% so far this year as climate change, unseasonal rains, hailstorms, and snowfall have caused severe damage to the crop. So far, 1.15 crore apple boxes have reached the market compared to 2.18 crore boxes last year, State Horticulture Director Satish Kumar said on Thursday. PTI

Amount released to implement anti-atrocities laws

1,423 in ₹ crore. The Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment on Thursday said the Centre has released ₹1,423.30 crore to States and Union Territories over the last three financial years for implementation of the Protection of Civil Rights Act, 1955 and the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989. PTI

Average price of diesel at the pump across the EU

2.24 € per litre. The average price of diesel at the pump across the EU has hit a record of €2.24 per litre — equivalent to \$9.60 per U.S. gallon — compared with €1.59 before war erupted in West Asia, according to EU Commission data. The data reflect prices at filling stations, either at the start of the week or at the end of the previous week. AFP

Officials to be probed for betting by Turkish football federation

450 Turkish Football Federation (TFF) says it has referred some 450 club officials to the disciplinary board as part of a probe into betting. The announcement came a day after the Justice Minister announced the arrest of the head of Turkiye's football refereeing body and six other people as part of a graft probe. AFP

Rise in coal supply by CIL to power sector in July-September

11 in per cent. Coal India Limited said the supply of dry fuel to the power sector users has increased by 11.01% to 148.20 million tonnes (MT) in the second quarter of the current financial year. The supply has firmed up ahead of the festive season and is likely to help ensure adequate availability of coal at thermal power plants, CIL said. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Sri Lanka: chasing system change

The NPP govt. restored macroeconomic stability and introduced a different political culture, but key promises of structural reform remain unfulfilled; two years after Dissanayake's election, the govt. faces the challenge of turning the *Aragalaya's* demand for 'system change' into lasting political transformation

WORLD INSIGHT

Meera Srinivasan

The mass uprising in Sri Lanka in the summer of 2022 had one unifying chant – “Gota go home”, reflecting the protesting citizens’ chief demand that then President Gotabaya Rajapaksa resign.

It was one of many diverse chants, their tone ranging from witty irreverence to daring dissent, that captured the spirit of the *Janata Aragalaya*, or people’s struggle. The protesters were emphatic in their rejection of Mr. Gotabaya, whom they held responsible for the country’s bankruptcy and their endless wait in queues amid acute shortages. They were unafraid to voice their anger with the Rajapaksa clan and their frustration with the entire political class.

But in that watershed moment, they were thirsty for something else, something new – “system change”, their posters screamed.

Once the Rajapaksas grudgingly quit office and Ranil Wickremesinghe took charge, with the Rajapaksas’ party backing him in an urgent parliamentary vote, the protests fizzled out. The many fragments of the movement had varied reactions to Mr. Wickremesinghe’s rule. To some, he was an experienced leader capable of facing the challenge of fixing the country’s battered economy. Others, however, saw him as embodying a continuation of the Rajapaksa rule, except in a suit. It was far from the political and systemic overhaul they had sought. That is why Anura Kumara Disسانayake’s campaign in 2024, promising to change the “corrupt political system,” found resonance with voters. It was the first election held since the economic crisis. Although led by the leftist Janatha Vimukthi Peramuna (JVP), a party tainted by its history of brutal violence, the broader National People’s Power (NPP) coalition Mr. Dissanayake founded (in 2019) and built up in the subsequent years emerged as a new force offering rare promise. Voters who had until then switched between one of two legacy political formations alternating at the country’s helm felt they had a real choice.

Two years on

Short of a clear majority in the three-cornered presidential race – he secured 42.31 % of the votes – Mr. Dissanayake made it with his tally of preferential votes. His impressive win propelled the NPP to a historic supermajority in the general elections that soon followed. Citizens who seemed torn or tentative in the September presidential polls were certain in November 2024. They were going to give “AKD” and his government a real chance. “I am not a magician; I am not a miracle-worker. There are things I know and don’t know,” Mr. Dissanayake said soon after being sworn in on September 23, 2024. “But I will commit to always doing the right thing, and to lead a collective effort to rebuild our nation,” the new President said in his first address to the country.

Last week, President Dissanayake completed two years in office. He has been addressing rallies across the country as part of a series titled ‘People’s Rule – Two Years Strong. Progress for All’.

Leading a country struggling to recover from a financial crash was never going to be easy. A year into forming government, the Dissanayake administration faced the



GETTY IMAGES

deadliest natural disaster the country had witnessed since the Indian Ocean tsunami in 2004. Cyclone Ditwah claimed nearly 700 lives and displaced several thousand people, even as nearly 1,200 landslides swallowed villages in the island’s hilly regions in late 2025. Within months, the West Asian crisis began, resulting in volatile fuel prices in the global market.

Wasting no time after it came to power, the NPP government prioritised economic stability and recovery.

The government opted to go ahead with the International Monetary Fund programme finalised by its predecessors, staunchly pursued fiscal discipline and macroeconomic stability as the IMF spelled them out, and achieved or even surpassed crucial targets set by the Fund. While the ruling administration initially referred to the IMF programme as a compulsion in the economic and social circumstances in the country, it gradually began following through with conviction. Meanwhile, studies have found that poor families are eating less, as they struggle to cope with crushing austerity.

“We surpassed the target revenue last year and cut down on unnecessary state expenses. It was because of this discipline that we were able to respond to Cyclone Ditwah and the West Asian crisis without passing on the burden to the public,” says Nihal Abeysinghe, General Secretary of the NPP and Member of Parliament.

Speaking to *The Hindu* at the JVP party headquarters on the NPP administration’s performance, Dr. Abeysinghe said it has “changed the political culture”. The Dissanayake government has made a series of high-profile arrests, especially of notorious suspects in the narcotics underworld and prominent politicians and bureaucrats accused of grand corruption. The arrest of a former intelligence chief in connection with the ongoing probe into the 2019 Easter terror bombings raised eyebrows. “Law

enforcement is the same for all, whether it is a former president or anyone else,” Dr. Abeysinghe says.

Pending promises

According to him, the government will focus on the Provincial Council elections and drafting a new constitution in the three years that remain of its term. Both were among the key promises the NPP made to Tamil voters. While the conduct of the provincial polls remains stuck with a parliamentary committee, there has been no movement yet on the promised new constitution.

The government’s efforts to bring about legislative changes remain in sharp focus for both its eagerness in some respects and its lethargy in others. Its recent move to introduce a constitutional amendment extending judges’ retirement age drew flak from the political opposition and legal community, which accused the government of using the judiciary to serve its political interests. The NPP’s pledge to repeal Sri Lanka’s draconian anti-terror legislation and abolish the executive presidency, too, remains only in the manifesto. Rights defenders have slammed draft legislation replacing – and not only repealing – the Prevention of Terrorism Act for falling short of international human rights standards.

‘Mixed’ report card

Offering a “mixed” report card for the NPP rule over the last two years, Pradeep Peiris, a political scientist at the University of Colombo, says he is “100% pleased” that the country “finally has a civilised, dignified polity”. All the same, he is “frustrated that an important turning point increasingly looks like another lost opportunity to address structural issues in our democracy.”

The NPP government, in his view, looks more like a “government of good

governance”, rather than one of transformation. “We must remember that 2024 was not just any other election, with its outcome bringing about a regime change. After 1948 [Independence], it was the first time citizens felt they could negotiate a new political structure”. Observing that the *Aragalaya* popularised a democratic imagination, Mr. Peiris adds: “While voters rejected the old political class in the 2024 election, it was not really a baptism of a new political class.” The electorate’s verdict, he cautions, was more a rejection of old politics than affirmation of the NPP’s programme. “While the country was very clear about what it did not want, it is not as clear about what it wants, and even less clear about how to get there. The NPP government needs to initiate a robust, inclusive conversation on renegotiating a new social contract with citizens.”

Contending that a cultural project is necessary for real political transformation, he notes that such a project is yet to take off. “In that sense, I feel instead of utilising this historic moment for system change, the NPP has simply become better rulers in the same system they inherited. In such a situation, the risk of the old political order returning always lingers,” he notes.

There is every indication that the NPP is hoping for a second term in office. “The opposition is weak, divided, and has no clear work plan. We don’t have a real political challenge yet, and we won’t until a new force better than us emerges,” Dr. Abeysinghe says with confidence.

Meanwhile, the NPP knows that it has its task cut out for it to ensure that its supporters across the country hold on to the hope they felt in 2024. Weeks before he was elected President, Mr. Dissanayake seemed fully aware of the challenge that awaited him if he won. “The people have very high expectations now,” he told *The Hindu* at the time.

THE GIST

▼ The NPP government has largely stayed the course with the IMF programme, maintained fiscal discipline, and met or surpassed several key economic targets despite major external shocks

▼ Its record includes high-profile corruption and narcotics-related arrests, but proposed legislative and constitutional reforms, including Provincial Council polls and a new constitution, have seen limited progress

▼ Political scientist Pradeep Peiris sees the NPP as a government of good governance rather than transformation, arguing that it needs a broader conversation with citizens on a new social contract

FULL CONTEXT

The forgotten villages at the heart of Delhi’s urban history

Delhi’s villages were integral to the city’s history, but colonial surveys, land acquisition and urbanisation transformed their land and communities; as Delhi expands, preserving the heritage and living traditions of Delhi *Dehat* remains a challenge

Shekhar Tokas

On September 11, 1803, on the banks of the Yamuna at present-day Patparganj in East Delhi, the British East India Company forces defeated the Maratha army and gained control of Delhi. It was a decisive turning point in the city’s history. The battle marked not only a shift in political power but also the beginning of a new phase of surveying, mapping and appropriation of Delhi’s rural landscape.

The rural landscape before the Raj
At the beginning of the 19th century, Delhi was dotted with distinct ecological zones. The fertile *khadar* stretched along the Yamuna, while the *pahari* tract occupied the natural triangle formed by the Aravalli hills to the north, south and south-east, with the river defining its eastern boundary. To the south-west lay the low-lying *dabar* around the Sahibi river, while the fertile agricultural plains of the *bangar* marked the north-west. These zones were home to village communities whose livelihoods centred on cultivation and animal husbandry, with cattle, camels and goats forming part of everyday rural life.

For centuries, these agrarian settlements supplied food, labour, water, military recruits, artisans and cultural traditions to successive urban centres. These settlements were not peripheral to Delhi’s history. They were part of what made the city possible. The *Ain-i-Akbari* records the region’s crops, revenues and land conditions, including Palam, which contributed 5,726,787 dams in revenue. Govil’s study of Siraspur (1803-1880) similarly shows the village’s close links with Delhi through land, revenue and property relations. Siraspur, now in North Delhi near Samaypur Badli and Rohini, survives as a reminder of this once-extensive rural hinterland.

From village land to colonial property
With the British consolidation of Delhi after 1803, the countryside entered a new phase. From 1837, revenue surveys began to map, classify and regulate village lands – including fields and commons (*shamilat deh*) – with a degree of systematic documentation that transformed customary rights into colonial administrative categories.

But Delhi’s villagers were never simply anonymous cultivators. They had their own systems of landholding, cultivation, kinship, lineage and customary rights, supported by institutions of village life. *Bhats* preserved these histories through genealogies that recorded ancestry, settlement and links between families and land. Gradually, however, colonial records – *shajra naksh*, *khasra* and settlement registers – became the state’s official records of land and rights.

The 1880 settlement of Kanjhawala shows what was at stake. Around a quarter of the recorded land was held as common land, supporting grazing and other collective needs. As these commons were later classified, divided and transferred, the change was not merely administrative. It reshaped the relationship between Delhi’s village communities, their land and the collective resources on which rural life depended. Every map broadly divided village land



The rural landscape of Munirka village in 1959, viewed from the site of present-day Priya Park. The havelis of Munirka and a tomb are visible. The R.K. Puram Sectors 4 and 5 can also be seen, marking the early stages of urbanisation in the area. MISSION FOR INDIAN HISTORY AND ARCHAEOLOGY, UNIVERSITY OF TOKYO, IN 1959-60

into three types: *abadi deh*, the village settlement; *zari/pahāi arāzi*, agricultural or hilly land; and *shamilat deh*, village commons. The *shajra naksh* showed the village and its different parcels of land, while each parcel was identified by a number, known as a *khasra* number.

These were more than administrative maps. Read alongside the *shajra nasab*, *jamabandi* and *khatauni*, which documented lineage, land rights, ownership and cultivation accounts, these records revealed patterns of settlement, landholding and kinship. Together, these records made village land easier for the colonial state to identify, assess and regulate. Four land-revenue settlements followed, culminating in 1880. The British systematically surveyed and mapped individual fields, assigning numbers that linked land to revenue and ownership records. For village families, land held through generations was increasingly documented not through *bhats*, customary knowledge and community relationships, but through official field numbers and assessed revenue. Ancestral rights were thus drawn into a formal colonial system of property and fiscal control. In 1880, *Zaildari* and *Nambardari* further extended this system of revenue collection. Delhi District was organised into three tehsils, 44 zails and hundreds of villages, including 375 villages across 18 zails in the area broadly corresponding to present-day Delhi.

The 1908 Lal Dora system further formalised village boundaries by separating *abadi* from agricultural land. After Delhi became the imperial capital in 1911, land acquisition transformed this system of control into large-scale displacement. Around 30 villages lost land for New Delhi, including Raisina for the Viceroy’s House, Khairpur for what became Lodhi Garden, and Pilanji and Malcha for parts of Chanakyapuri. Raisina remains a striking example: its agricultural land was acquired in 1911-12, and more than a century later,

descendants continue to seek compensation in the Delhi High Court.

After independence, another transformation followed. The state increasingly acquired agricultural land while leaving village *abadi deh* intact. As fields gave way to roads, institutions and neighbourhoods, the rural landscape gradually disappeared from official maps and from the historical consciousness of the expanding city. The settlements remained, producing the paradox of the “urban village” - rural settlements engulfed by urbanisation. The supposedly “unplanned” urban village, therefore, is not outside Delhi’s planning history; it is one of its products.

Whose history is remembered?
But the story of Delhi’s villages is not only a story of land. It is also a story about what gets remembered as history. Why do we remember Delhi through its kings, empires, monuments and imperial buildings more readily than through the villages and communities that surrounded them? History is not simply the past; it is the way the past is remembered, interpreted and represented. Historians reconstruct the past from fragments of surviving evidence, and the past is always larger than the evidence that survives.

Collingwood’s *The Idea of History*, Bloch’s *The Historian’s Craft*, and Carr’s *What Is History* remind us that history is not simply found in archives; it is reconstructed through questions, evidence and interpretation. This has an important implication for Delhi *Dehat*. Its history lies not only in official records but also in village maps, land documents, landscapes, material remains and oral memories.

The history of Munirka, as reconstructed in *Mhara Munirka: Story of an Urban Village*, illustrates this process. The book brings together oral histories, accounts preserved by *bhats*, old British-period maps, land acquisition documents and surviving structures such

as *havelis*, ponds, wells, *chaupals* and temples to recover the history of the village.

The *bhats*, who preserved genealogies and memories of families and their ancestry, provide an important source for recovering histories that may not appear in official records. Recovering these sources allows us to see Delhi not merely as a planned metropolis, but as a city shaped by villages whose histories have often remained outside its dominant narrative. The absence of Delhi’s villages from dominant histories does not mean they have no history. It raises a deeper question: whose experiences and sources have shaped the historical record?

The future of Delhi Dehat
Delhi’s villages were never leftover spaces waiting to be urbanised. They helped make the city. As Delhi plans for 2047, the question is not simply how these villages will be absorbed, but what happens to their communities, heritage, livelihoods and remaining commons. Will future planning protect their *abadi*, historic structures and local institutions, or displace them once again? Delhi’s future will depend not only on what it builds, but on what it chooses to retain.

Even the term *Dehat* deserves reconsideration. The distinction between *shahar* and *dehat* obscures the continuities between rural and urban Delhi. Katwaria Sarai village, surrounded by IIT Delhi, the Indian Statistical Institute and the Qutub Institutional Area, still retains its *jhod* (pond), *akhada* (traditional wrestling pit), Guru Gorakhnath *Mandir*, *Valmiki Mandir* and *Daulat ki Haveli*. Across Delhi, villages continue to preserve rurality through their built heritage, festivals, rituals, language, food and everyday practices. Delhi *Dehat* is therefore not a space outside the city, but a living part of it. (Shekhar Tokas is an Assistant Professor of Urban Studies at Dr. B. R. Ambedkar University Delhi)

THE DAILY QUIZ

A quiz on the Father of the Nation on his 157th birth anniversary

V.V. Ramanan

QUESTION 1
Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi had three siblings. If Raliyatbehn was the sister, who were the two brothers?

QUESTION 2
It is said that when he embarked for England, Gandhiji carried a letter of introduction to a cricketer who was a schoolmate. Name this sporting legend.

QUESTION 3
An incident that took place on the night of June 7, 1893, acted as a catalyst for Gandhiji to fight against race and colour prejudices. What and where?

QUESTION 4
Name the two main ‘ashrams’ set up

by Gandhiji in South Africa.

QUESTION 5
After many campaigns, activities and arrests in South Africa, Gandhiji returned to India for good on January 9, 1915. How is the date commemorated now?

QUESTION 6
Who was responsible for giving Mohandas Gandhi the title ‘Mahatma’, and who first referred to him as ‘Rashtriyapitha’ (Father of the Nation)?

QUESTION 7
Which genius paid this wonderful tribute to Gandhiji: “Generations to come will scarce believe that such a one as this ever in flesh and blood walked upon this earth”?



Visual Question:
Name the famous gentleman seated alongside Gandhiji. THE HINDU ARCHIVES

Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz: 1. Name the place from where Baba Budan is said to have brought coffee beans to India, and how has the place’s name become part of coffee lore? **Ans: Mocha in Yemen, and a chocolate-flavoured coffee is called mocha** 2. What is the biggest contribution of Melitta Bentz and Achille Gaggia to the modern world of coffee brewing? **Ans: Paper coffee-filter system and espresso machine** 3. After which event did drinking coffee acquire a particularly patriotic significance among some American colonists as an alternative to tea? **Ans: Boston Tea Party of 1773** 4. What is the common name for the coffee species called ‘Coffea canephora’? **Ans: Robusta** 5. Which famous brand was officially launched in 1938 to help surplus Brazilian coffee crops? **Ans: Nescafé instant coffee** 6. Which famous composer wrote a comic opera called ‘Coffee Cantata’? **Ans: Johann Sebastian Bach** 7. What is the name given to a trained professional who prepares espresso-based and other coffee drinks? **Ans: Barista** Visual: This expensive coffee consists of partially digested coffee cherries that have been eaten and defecated by which animal? **Ans: Asian Palm Civet** **Early Birds:** K.N. Viswanathan | Tariqa Bali | Tilo Shiladitya | Sunil Madhavan | Tamal Biswas



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the meaning of “It isn’t worth a hill of beans”? (J. V. Subba Rao, Hyderabad)

When you say something “isn’t worth a hill of beans”, what you are implying is that it is insignificant; it is worthless. This is an expression which is normally used in informal contexts.

What is the difference between “homicide” and “murder”? (R. Ganesan, Madurai)

“Homicide” is a word frequently used in American English. It refers to the killing of one human being by another. The killing may be accidental or intentional. If you shoot a man accidentally or in self-defense, it would be considered “homicide”; similarly, if you run over an individual intentionally, it would be considered “homicide”. It is a neutral term. According to Black’s Law Dictionary, the word homicide merely “describes the act; it pronounces no judgment on the moral or legal quality”.

Murder, on the other hand, is an illegal act; it is usually a premeditated crime. When an individual “murders” someone, he/she kills another human being after having planned what he/she is going to do. The word “murder” has a negative connotation associated with it. The police force in the United States has a Homicide Department, but not a Murder Department. The “o” in the first syllable of “homicide” is like the “o” in “hot”, “pot”, and “not”, while the “i” in the second syllable is like the “a” in “china”. The final syllable is pronounced like the word “side”. The main stress is on the first syllable.

Is it ok to say “I am running forty”? (K. Chandrasekaran, Sivaganga)

We Indians are always in a hurry. When we are on the road, we are in a rush to get somewhere; sometimes totally ignoring all traffic rules. So it is not surprising that we are always “running” some particular age. It is very common to hear an Indian say that he is “running 40”. I suppose when one is 39, one can run to 40. But when one is 79, does one run/jog/canter/limp/crawl to 80? I have no idea. The expression “running 40” is common within the Indian context. Native speakers tend to use “going on”. Remember the famous song from “The Sound of Music”? “I am sixteen going on seventeen”. Is it wrong to say “running 40”? Within the Indian context, it is acceptable.

What is the meaning of “the straw that broke the camel’s back”? (A Vara Prasad, Tuni, A.P.)

When you say that something is the straw that broke the camel’s back, what you are implying is that you have reached the limit of your patience; that you are not willing to put up with any more nonsense.

Sriram is always late for office. On Friday, he failed to meet an important client. That was the straw that broke the camel’s back. The boss fired him.

It is also possible to say “the last straw”. For example,

When he broke the window for the third time, it was the last straw.

There is a limit as to the amount of straw that any animal can carry. A camel, for example, can carry a certain amount on its back. If you keep adding to the amount, then the animal will become overloaded. That final straw is the straw that breaks the camel’s back. The idiom has been in use since the mid 1800s. *Published in The Hindu on February 26, 2002*

Word of the day

Subterfuge:
something intended to misrepresent the true nature of an activity

Synonyms: deception, trickery, deceptiveness, secrecy

Usage: *His excuse was just subterfuge to hide what he had really done.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/subterfuge

International Phonetic Alphabet: /sʌbtəʃfjuːʒ/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Text & Context’

From Page One

UAE probes ‘terror’ link to flight incident

The UAE’s chief prosecutor said an investigation had been launched into the incident, including the possibility of “terrorist activity or intent”. Mr. Netanyahu said he expected the UAE to take the lead in the investigation, but that Israel would join.

Israel’s far-right National Security Minister, Itamar Ben Gvir, called it a “jihadist” attack, while Defence Minister Israel Katz also described the incident as “an attempted jihadist terror attack”.

Mr. Trump was asked by presspersons at the White House whether he had been briefed about any links between the pilot behind the attack and Tehran. He responded, “I would say the answer, based on what I’m hearing, is yes, but we’re working on it right now. He did not offer details.

Asked if the U.S. would retaliate against Tehran if it was behind the attack, Mr. Trump said, “Oh they’ll be hit, very hard, don’t worry.”

Airline flydubai has said all the passengers – of whom 166 out of 174 were Israeli – were safe, but that the reasons for the altercation were unknown.

“During the flight, as they approached the country, one of the pilots stabbed the other pilot, and apparently tried to crash the plane with everyone on board,” Mr. Netanyahu said in a video message.

He later hailed the wounded pilot, Mr. Machchhar, “for his extraordinary bravery”, saying he prevented a “catastrophic mid-air disaster”.

Indian embassy in Saudi Arabia said Mr. Machchhar was being treated at a hospital in the country.

Passenger Miryam Shira Ohayon described the plane as being “pretty much out of control” as the incident unfolded over Jordan. “The co-pilot tried to murder the pilot and basically carry out a suicide attack on the plane,” she told presspersons by speakerphone at Ben Gurion Airport.

(With inputs from AP)

EC orders probe into Form 7 fraud charge

In at least two instances, in Belagavi and Vijayapura, BJP workers who filed Form 7s in bulk withdrew those after being warned of punitive action if the claims were found to be false. In a written declaration, they said they had made a mistake.

The Karnataka Police registered five FIRs on Thursday over bulk Form 7s invoking the Bharatiya Nyay Sanhita, 2023, and not the Representation of the People Act, 1951, as only EC officials can lodge complaints under the latter. Mr. Shivakumar demanded that the poll body must take *suo motu* action and lodge criminal complaints.

Mr. Anbu Kumar noted that there were instances of bulk filing of Form 7 applications before the EROs and that some of the forms were “alleged to be not genuine” and directed the EROs to take action under Section 31 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950, “against applicants found to have knowingly made false statements or declarations.”

“However, such action shall be preceded by an inquiry under Rule 20 of the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960,” he said.

The BJP backed its workers for filing Form 7s, saying that it was not a crime to flag voters suspected to be not genuine.

Earlier in the day, Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, took to social media citing *The Hindu’s* report on how Form-7 applications were being filed against Muslim names in Belagavi and other districts in bulk, and said it was yet another proof of “vote theft”.

“Select people are targeted as BJP and EC officials collude to fill out Form 7 in bulk through automated means, and in the blink of an eye, millions vanish from the voter list. And all of this is controlled from the top,” he said.

Govt. hikes commercial LPG cylinder rate by ₹65

In July and August, the price was cumulatively slashed by ₹380 per cylinder. The reduction followed a hike of about ₹1,345 in four tranches since March 7.

Among the four metros, Kolkata saw the steepest hike. While a cylinder costs ₹2,810 in Delhi following a ₹62.5 upward revision, in Kolkata, it now costs ₹2,954 after a ₹70 jump.

In Mumbai, a cylinder costs ₹2,764.50 after a hike of ₹63.50, and in Chennai ₹2,983 following an increase of ₹66.50.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, Manpreet Singh, treasurer of the National Restaurants Association of India, said costlier LPG cylinders could prompt restaurateurs to increase the price of food items. “LPG is an important input for restaurateurs. Further, the latest hike coincides with food inflation, and increasing costs of labour, among other things. This puts restaurateurs under pressure,” he said.

Prashant Vashisht, senior vice-president and co-group head of corporate sector ratings at ICRA, said the latest hike seeks to factor in the recent increase in the benchmark Saudi Aramco Contract Price (Saudi CP).

“This could be possibly relating to the general increase in price of benchmark Saudi CP prices and not just to have some sort of compensatory mechanism for the larger domestic LPG segment,” he said.

President, PM hail pilot for his role in averting flight crisis

Modi says Smit Machchhar fought valiantly and prevented another 9/11-like attack from happening: Murmu lauds his ‘incredible presence of mind’

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Droupadi Murmu on Thursday hailed Captain Smit Machchhar, a flydubai pilot, for his role in averting a disaster involving a Dubai-Tel Aviv flight on Wednesday.

An Indian national, Captain Machchhar was stabbed by his co-pilot in an alleged attempt to crash the plane but managed to activate the release to open the cockpit door, allowing passengers to enter and overpower the co-pilot. Two flydubai pilots who were passengers on the aircraft helped the aircraft make a safe landing in Tabuk, Saudi Arabia.

Mr. Modi said that Captain Machchhar had shown the world the highest form of courage. Without fearing for his own life, Captain Machchhar fought valiant-



Smit Machchhar

ly and prevented another 9/11-like attack from happening, he said.

Mr. Modi said that 140 crore Indians saluted Captain Machchhar, who is now recovering at a hospital, and were praying for his well-being. He made the remarks while addressing the centenary celebrations of the Union Public Service Commission.

President Droupadi Murmu also lauded Captain Machchhar’s bravery.

“The nation is proud of Captain Smit Machchhar. His heroic courage and incredible presence of mind

have deeply touched us all. Even after being seriously injured in a moment of grave peril, he remained determined to protect the lives of others. His bravery and quick response helped prevent a major tragedy and saved many precious lives. I salute his indomitable spirit. I pray for his speedy recovery and good health,” she posted on X.

While addressing the UPSC event, Mr. Modi cautioned that future civil servants would have to navigate entirely new battlegrounds such as information warfare, deepfakes, algorithmic bias, and climate justice. He instructed recruitment agencies to adapt to these global shifts by prioritising candidates’ foresight and complex problem-solving abilities. “In such a scenario, in the selection process, we will also have to give priority to testing complex problem-solving and foresight,” he said.

With pride and prayers, Machchhar’s acquaintances await news of his recovery

Yohaán Ashish Varghese
MUMBAI

Pride over Captain Smit Machchhar’s bravery aboard flydubai flight FZ1073 was tempered by an anxious wait for news of his recovery on Thursday, as childhood friends, neighbours and residents in Mumbai’s Tilak Nagar, Chembur West, prayed for his safe return home.

Mr. Machchhar was hailed for his role in helping passengers and crew manage a safe landing.

The pilot was seriously injured during an attack inside the cockpit of the Dubai-Tel Aviv flight on Wednesday. Despite his injuries, he managed to unlock the cockpit door, allowing others on board to intervene.

The aircraft, carrying 174 passengers, was subsequently landed safely at Tabuk in Saudi Arabia. Machchhar underwent surgery before being shifted to Dubai for further treatment.

“It’s a proud moment for all of us as Mumbaikars, as people living in the same society, and as fellow



Artist Manas Kumar Sahoo pays tribute to Smit Machchhar’s bravery with a sand painting in Puri on Thursday. ANI

Indians,” said Yuhan Merchant, Machchhar’s neighbour. “At the same time, we are very concerned about his well-being. We just hope that he is fine.”

Mr. Merchant, who has known Machchhar and his family, described him as “tremendously dedicated” to aviation. “We just hope that he continues doing what he does best, and that’s falling in love with the aviation sector,” he said.

For Chintan, a childhood friend of Machchhar, the courage being spoken about across the world was not entirely unfamiliar. “I knew he was a very brave and large-hearted person, and today the whole world

knows it,” he said.

Neighbour Shifali Parekh said Mr. Machchhar’s response showed considerable mental strength.

“Imagine getting stabbed, then thinking about the flight going down, and then opening the door,” Ms. Parekh said.

BJP MLA Parag Shah said the connection was particularly personal for him as Machchhar was not only from his constituency but had also attended the same school as him.

According to Mr. Shah, Mr. Machchhar was stable following surgery and his family was receiving assistance from flydubai and Indian, Saudi and UAE authorities.

SC refuses Mamata camp’s petition to unfreeze accounts

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday declined a petition by Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool Congress faction to operate four bank accounts in public sector banks debit-frozen by the West Bengal Police.

Appearing before a Bench headed by Justice M.M. Sundresh, the petitioner faction argued that the first information reports (FIRs) related to the accounts’ freeze suffered from glaring procedural infirmities.

However, the Bench refused to entertain the petition under its appellate jurisdiction, and instead requested the Calcutta High Court to expedite the hearing of petitions filed

by Ms. Banerjee’s faction challenging the FIRs.

The High Court had declined to provide the faction any interim relief on August 27 regarding the frozen bank accounts which hold over ₹800 crore in them.

The High Court had reasoned that any interim order of the kind would pull the rug from under an earlier direction limiting the party’s access to its accounts only to meet daily or monthly expenses.

Earlier in August, the top court had declined to intervene in favour of the political party with regard to three other bank accounts frozen by the Directorate of Enforcement (ED) in connection with a money laundering investigation.

Cong. leader flags ‘rushed’ scrutiny of FCRA Bill in letter to LS Speaker

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Accusing the Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC) examining the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026 of rushing through the deliberations without adequate consultations with stakeholders, Congress general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal, in a letter to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, urged that the Bill should not be brought back to the floor of the House until the committee had completed a “genuine and comprehensive” examination.

The FCRA Amendment Bill, 2026 was introduced in the Lok Sabha on March 25, 2026 and subsequently referred to a 31-member JPC on August 12 following objections from Opposi-



tion parties, who contented that several provisions of the legislation were aimed at hampering the functioning of minority-led institutions.

The Opposition had especially pointed out provisions that allowed the transfer of an organisation’s funds and assets to a government-designated authority if the FCRA registration was cancelled or not renewed as particularly disturbing and anti-constitutional. Instead, arriv-

ing at a compromise, the government agreed to send the Bill to the JPC.

The decision to refer the Bill to a JPC carried a clear expectation that the committee would hear a broad spectrum of stakeholders, including NGOs, charitable and religious institutions, voluntary organisations, legal experts and State governments – and to bring before the House a well-considered and flawless Bill”, Mr. Ve-

nugopal said in the letter.

However, he claimed that “no meaningful consultation” with stakeholders was taking place, and that there was an intention to secure the passage of the Bill during the forthcoming Winter Session of Parliament. In an earlier letter signed by 12 of the Opposition MPs of the panel, the same concern had been flagged.

“If this is so, it would defeat the very purpose for which the House referred the Bill to the committee, and reduce an important parliamentary process to a mere formality,” Mr. Venugopal said, calling on the Speaker, as the “custodian of the House and its committees”, to ensure that the panel conducted a comprehensive exercise, and be given adequate time before submitting its report.

Committee on simultaneous elections Bill cancels SC visit

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The parliamentary committee examining the Bills on simultaneous elections has dropped its proposed October 6 visit to the Supreme Court for an interaction with judges. Committee chairperson P.P. Chaudhary, however, said on Thursday that the visit had been deferred because of scheduling difficulties.

The decision came after an Opposition MP wrote to Mr. Chaudhary expressing concern that any interaction with the judges on the proposed legislation could blur the separation of powers and raise questions about the institutional independence of Parliament and the judiciary.

Seeking the views of sitting judges on legislation that could later come before the Supreme Court, the MP said, could create an avoidable institutional overlap.

Bengal govt. obstructing her work as MP, says Mahua; SC seeks reply from Centre, State

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday sought responses from the Union government and the State of West Bengal to a petition filed by Krishnanagar MP Mahua Moitra alleging a concerted effort by the State authorities and the police, using goons and mobs, to impede her from freely accessing her constituency.

A Bench of Justices Joydalya Bagchi and V. Mohana asked Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing on behalf of both the Union and the State governments, to file counter-affidavits to the petition.

Ms. Moitra, represented by senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan and advocate Yashwant Singh, said since the shift in the State’s ruling dispensation in May 2026 which saw the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) come into power for



Mahua Moitra

the first time in West Bengal, the distinction between ‘party’ and the ‘government’ had been ‘obliterated’ in the State. Civil and police authorities had been covertly encouraged to “shun” a duly-elected Opposition MP, and “drive her out of her constituency only because of her political affiliation”.

‘Registration of FIRs’

“The new State government has made it impossible for the petitioner to function as an MP by seek-

ing to evict her from her local accommodation at the Circuit House and drive her into the hands of a politically charged mob; by holding up development works under the Member of Parliament Local Area Development (MPLAD) scheme; by not allowing her to hold any outdoor party or public meetings; tacitly allowing goons and mobs from the ruling party to physically attack her; and registration of multiple FIRs against her,” the petition said.

Any attempt by a State government to impede the functioning of a parliamentarian was a grave attack on the federal principle, Ms. Moitra said.

Civil and police authorities in Krishnanagar had, at the behest of their political bosses, refused to extend any support to her in the discharge of her duties as an MP since May 2026, she said.

Top court stays death penalty of convict in Gujarat blasts case

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday stayed the execution of the death sentence awarded to an Indian Mujahideen operative in the 2008 Ahmedabad serial bomb blasts case, in which 56 people were killed.

A Bench of Justices Vikram Nath, A.G. Masih and Sandeep Mehta passed the interim order while hearing an appeal filed by Ahmed Bawa, alias Abbu

Abubakar Barelvi, challenging the Gujarat High Court verdict affirming the death sentence imposed on him by the trial court.

The Bench issued notice to Gujarat government and called for the trial court records, while directing that the death sentence not be executed in the meantime.

Appearing for Barelvi, his counsel contended that his conviction rested entirely on the allegation that he was part of the conspiracy behind the blasts.

APPEAL

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HC says draft roll can't be basis for deleting names without hearing

The object of Representation of the People Act and EC is to ensure that votes are cast by citizens, the court says, adding poll body's endeavour is to have as many eligible voters on the roll as possible; expresses concern over automated deletions

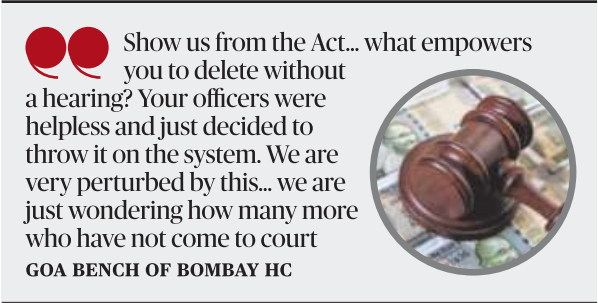
Press Trust of India
PANAJI

The Bombay High Court on Thursday said that the primary mandate of the Election Commission (EC) is to ensure that citizens cast their votes, and asserted that while the poll body questions voter conduct, citizens are equally within their rights to ask why exercises such as the special intensive revision (SIR) are ordered after decades.

Hearing a petition filed by six family members whose names were deleted from the voter list, the High Court's Goa Bench, comprising Justices Valmiki Menezes and Amit S. Jamsandekar, said the EC's action was not in consonance with its mandate.

As per the plea filed by Paresh Salgaonkar and his family, they had moved to a new house in the same Santa Cruz Assembly constituency and were instructed by the booth-level officer (BLO) to submit Form 8 for a change of address.

At the time of processing these forms, they said,



errors showed up since no record of their elector photo to identity cards (EPIC) was found, and as such, the only option available in the ERONet software was "reject". Their Form 8 was rejected, following which they approached the High Court.

The EC's advocate Gaurish Agni questioned why the petitioners had not notified authorities of their relocation earlier, to which the Bench remarked "the petitioner will also ask why this SIR after 24 years because he is a citizen of India, why not in between, because the number could have been controllable".

The court added that such discrepancies would never arise if updating electoral rolls was a continuous process.

"It is not about the blame game," the judges noted, pointing out that authorities have access to birth and death records and should automatically update rolls, enrolling people as soon as they turn 18.

The object of the Representation of the People Act and the EC is to ensure that votes are cast by citizens, the court said, adding the election body's endeavour is to have as many eligible voters on the roll as possible. "For that purpose, they can adopt any measures. Whatever measures that you adopt, the object has to be achieved. In that object, here and there, there may be aberrations. But the object cannot be overridden," the Bench asserted.

It noted that instead of

rejecting the Form 8, the authorities could have kept it in abeyance and taken it up after the SIR was completed.

"Because what happens is that if you don't keep it pending, the person escapes from the roll... You finish your roll and deal with all the Form 8s. Because that is the best information for you to understand that people have shifted," the court observed.

'Automated deletions'

Expressing deep concern over the automated deletions, the Bench questioned the EC's authority to drop names without giving electors a hearing.

"Show us from the Act... what empowers you to delete without a hearing? Your officers were helpless and just decided to throw it on the system. We are very perturbed by this... we are just wondering how many more who have not come to court," it said and pointed out that such rejections risk taking lakhs of legitimate voters off the rolls.

The Bench had, during the earlier hearing on Wednesday, said the draft roll under the SIR cannot be the basis for deletion of names from the voter list and held that administrative software cannot supersede statutory laws to disenfranchise voters.

The court ruled that the draft roll cannot be the basis for deletion of voters' names. "Otherwise, Form 6, 7 or 8 have no meaning. Form 6, 7 and 8 are specifically for either a person who is a new voter, a person who has lost the right to vote, or a person who is shifting," the court said on Wednesday.

The court told the EC that the "software system did not allow" it to accept Form 8. "He was never a new voter. He became new for your system," it said.

The Bench questioned the EC on the provisions empowering it to delete names without a hearing.

The Bench said that once a Form 8 is received, the authority must "apply its mind and see whether this person has really moved (to a new address)".

The court will hear the plea further on October 5.

Who ordered changes to Form 6, asks Rahul Gandhi

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Thursday alleged that the online Form 6, which is used for fresh voter registration, was changed "illegally" and asked who at the Election Commission ordered Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) to make that change.

Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh claimed that the change in Form 6 was orchestrated by "the PM-HM duo" to remove Gen Z voters from the voter list. Quoting an interview given to *The Hindu* by former Chief Election Commissioner O.P. Rawat, Mr. Ramesh said the chorus of voices against the capture of the electoral system is getting louder.

ERONet application

According to the 2024-25 annual report of the Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), the EC collaborated with technology firm and developed flagship web-based application "ERONet 2.0".

Earlier, ERONet was managed by the Centre for Development of Advanced Computing (C-DAC), which comes under the Ministry



Rahul Gandhi

of Electronics and Information Technology.

"ERONet 2.0 application has a centralised database that serves as the single source of truth for the election body. A standout feature is the executive dashboard, which is updated daily and offers a 360-degree view of the lifecycle of electors," the company said in its customer stories section.

"The ERO Net 2.0 suite of applications includes BLO mobile application which plays a critical role for all elections in the country. As the primary technology partner, TCS helped the election body give a digital makeover to electoral roll management. The application that TCS developed was rolled out nationwide within seven months of launch, with complete functionalities and data migration. It al-

lows over 1.05 million nationwide officials to handle elector registrations, updates, and deletions efficiently," it further said.

In January 2026, the Election Commission (EC) integrated ERONet (Electoral Registration Officers Network) into a comprehensive umbrella platform, known as ECINet.

Mr. Gandhi, in a post on X, alleged: "The online Form 6 was changed illegally – as the EC's own Commissioners have recorded. Who at the EC ordered Tata Consultancy Services to make that change? He also questioned whether TCS was 'pressured' into doing it?"

According to contribution reports of various electoral trusts for 2024-25, which are available on the Election Commission's website, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) received ₹959 crore as political donations from various electoral trusts in 2024-25, out of which nearly ₹757 crore, which is 83% of the total donations to the party, came from Tata Group-controlled Progressive Electoral Trust (PET).

Tagging an interview by Mr. Rawat, Mr. Ramesh said: "Citizens will no longer tolerate vote chori (theft) in any form."

People will not forgive those who snatch their voting rights: Mamata

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The people of India will not forgive those responsible for snatching away their voting rights, former West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee said on Thursday, even as she predicted an early demise of the Narendra Modi government before it completes its third term in 2029.

Addressing a press conference in the national capital, Ms. Banerjee – flanked by MPs from her faction of the Trinamool Congress from both Houses of Parliament, including her nephew Abhishek Banerjee – also questioned the immunity provision for the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) and Election



Former West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee at a press conference in New Delhi on Thursday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Commissioners under a 2023 law.

"We believe that this time, the BJP will go and we do not have to wait up to 2029. See what happens. The game has begun," Ms. Banerjee said.

Her remarks came a day after the INDIA bloc meet-

ing. Responding to a question on the alliance's prospects and her endorsement of Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi as the bloc's Prime Ministerial face, she said the Opposition should first focus on immediate political issues, including the

functioning of the Election Commission of India (EC).

"See how long it will go on. Two months, three months, six months. I am not an astrologer. But I think, very soon, you will get the good news," she said.

'Hijacked election'

Alleging that the West Bengal Assembly election was "hijacked", Ms. Banerjee claimed the Election Commission had centralised the special intensive revision (SIR) of the State's electoral rolls, the State police functioned as a BJP wing, Opposition counting agents were forced out of polling booths, and 4,000 electronic voting machines (EVMs) were burnt without anyone being apprehended.

Plea in SC questions judge's failure to disclose his son's role as EC's counsel

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

A petitioner in a case challenging the Election Commissioners' appointment law, which culminated in a split verdict, orally mentioned on Thursday his application questioning why one of the judges on the Bench, Justice Satish Chandra Sharma, did not reveal during multiple court proceedings that his son was a standing counsel for the Election Commission.

The application was mentioned before Justice Dipankar Datta, the lead judge on the Bench that delivered the split verdict on September 23. Justice Datta asked the petitioner-applicant to mention his plea before the Chief Justice of India. The CJJ is not

holding court on Friday. The next working day for the court is October 5.

The application was filed by Naman Sherstra, represented by senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan and advocate Pawan Reley. Mr. Sherstra has sought a recall of the opinion given by Justice Sharma, who was the puisne judge on the Division Bench headed by Justice Datta, on September 23, on the question of referring the challenge to the constitutional validity of the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023 to a five-judge Bench.

While Justice Datta, in his opinion, had declined

the reference to a Constitution Bench, Justice Sharma took an opposing view in favour of the reference. Eventually, both judges on the Bench had passed a common order for the Chief Justice of India to allocate the case to a Constitution Bench.

The application has objected to this common order but did not challenge, specifically, the separate opinion given by Justice Datta.

Seek recall

Subsequent to the September 23 verdict, media reports had alleged that Justice Sharma's son was a standing counsel for the EC.

Another petitioner, Jaya Thakur, has already filed a curative petition on Sep-

tember 29 to recall the split verdict, alleging "reasonable apprehension of bias and propriety".

Mr. Sherstra, though similarly seeking a recall, did not impute "actual bias, motive or want of good faith" on the part of Justice Sharma.

"The petitioners state that had the engagement of Mr. Siddharth Sharma as standing counsel for the EC been disclosed during the hearings, they would have requested that Justice Satish Chandra Sharma recuse from the present batch. The absence of disclosure deprived the petitioners of an opportunity to raise that request before the opinions and order dated September 23 were pronounced," the application submitted.

Protest by CJP against CEC in Mumbai today

Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) will kickstart a country-wide protest seeking the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar from October 2 from Mumbai, its founder Abhijeet Dipke said on Thursday. After Mumbai, the group will hold protests in six other cities.

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4. Tender paper cost	: Rs.10,000/- per each tender (Non refundable)
5. EMD required	: As mentioned in Section No.1 of DTGN (Clause No.6)
6. Class of contractor	: As mentioned in Section No.1 of DTGN (Clause No.1)
7. Period of completion	: As mentioned in Section No.1 of DTGN (Clause No.8)
8. Online for bidding	: 07.10.2026 at 10.00 hrs. to 22.10.2026 up to 17.30 hrs.
9. Date & time of opening of Tender (Technical bid)	: 23.10.2026 at 11.30 hrs.

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9 Date of Technical Presentation (among qualified bidders only)	Date & Time will be notified after opening of the Technical Bid.
10	"The Bidders have to participate in ONLINE bidding only. Further details can also be seen from the website: https://tendersodisha.gov.in . Any addendum/corrigendum/cancellation of tender shall not be published in Newspaper and can only be seen in the said website. "The Authority reserves the right to reject any or all bids and terminate the tender process without assigning any reason thereof.

Sd/- Chief Engineer (OSPH&WC)

N.B.-The quoted rate should be all inclusive but excluding G.S.T. as applicable Under works contract.
12001/159/2627 OIPR-12001/12025/1/26-27/0017

KERALA STATE COUNCIL FOR SCIENCE, TECHNOLOGY AND ENVIRONMENT (KSCSTE)
Sasthrabhavan, Pattom, Thiruvananthapuram - 695004,
Phone : 0471 - 2548316, Website: www.kscste.kerala.gov.in

NOTIFICATION

The KSCSTE is seeking qualified candidates for the post of Executive Director, KSCSTE-CWRDM

For details log on to www.kscste.kerala.gov.in.
Last date for the receipt of application is **17.10.2026, 5.00 p.m**

D3/577/2026/I&PRD EXECUTIVE VICE PRESIDENT

कार्यालय जोधपुर विकास प्राधिकरण, जोधपुर

क्रमांक :- अ.अ./पीएचई/2026-27/राजकल 24826774 दिनांक :- 01/10/2026

ई-बिड सूचना संख्या:- जोन (पीएचई)/14/26-27 दिनांक 01.10.2026

जोधपुर विकास प्राधिकरण, जोधपुर की ओर से सौखरेज के कार्य हेतु संवेदकों से निर्धारित प्रपत्र में ई-प्रोक्युरमेंट प्रक्रिया से ऑनलाइन निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती है। इन उक्त कार्य की अनुमानित लागत, निविदा वेबे जाला प्राप्त करने की दिनांक, निविदा शर्तें आदि का सम्पूर्ण विवरण वेबसाईट <http://www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, www.jodhpurjda.org, www.sppp.raj.nic.in पर देखा जा सकता है।

NIB Code :- JOD2627A0199
UBN No. :- JOD2627WSOB00371
राज.संवाद/बी/26/11115 अतिथिगी अतिथिता (पीएचई)

राजस्थान स्कुल शिक्षा परिषद्

मुख्यालय, कोट-6, बी.एस. स्टाफ़ावास बिल्डिंग, कोट, जयपुर
फ़ोन नं: 0141-2700489, E-Mail:- RAJMSA.CIVIL@RAJASTHAN.GOV.IN

क्रमांक :- F-5(1)(325)RSCCE/Civil/NIT 2026-27/2026/D-3982 दिनांक :- 25/09/2026

अल्पकालीन ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या 13 (सिविल)/2026-27
(राजकीय विद्यालय/केजीवी में मरम्मत कार्य हेतु)

राज्य एवं केन्द्र सरकार के राजकीय/अर्द्धराजकीय/स्वायत्तशासी निकायों में सहाय श्रेणी मरम्मत कार्य हेतु पंजीकृत संवेदकों से समग्र शिक्षा योजनाअन्तर्गत राजकीय विद्यालय/केजीवी में मरम्मत कार्य के लिए वार्षिक दर संविदा हेतु 139 ब्लॉकों में राशि रु. 15000.98 लाख (प्रति ब्लॉक की राशि रुपये 100.00 लाख से 251.68 लाख के मध्य) बाबत कार्यवार ई-टेंडरिंग के माध्यम से अल्पकालीन ई-निविदाएं 29/09/2026 प्रातः 10.00 बजे से 08/10/2026 को सार्व 6.00 बजे तक आमंत्रित की जाती है।

UBN No. :- RSE2627WSOB011391

निविदा से सम्बंधित समस्त विस्तृत विवरण वेबसाईट <http://rajsmsa.nic.in>, <http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in> एवं <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> पर देखा जा सकता है। निविदा से सम्बंधित प्रक्रिया जिला परिषदोजना समन्वयक, समग्र शिक्षा कार्यालय सम्बंधित जिला के स्तर से की जावेगी।

राज्य परिषदोजना निदेशक संस्था शिक्षा
राज.संवाद/बी/26/11025

APPOINTMENT

भारतीय प्रौद्योगिकी संस्थान गुवाहाटी
INDIAN INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY GUWAHATI
गुवाहाटी - 781039, Guwahati - 781 039

Vacancy of Manager - Strategic Partnerships & Philanthropy and Assistant Project Engineer

IIT Guwahati invites applications from eligible individuals for temporary positions of Manager - Strategic Partnerships & Philanthropy and Assistant Project Engineer. Details of the posts are available at IIT Guwahati website: https://iitg.ac.in/iitg_req_details?pe=4473/advertisement-for-positions-of-manager.

Last Date of application: 20-10-2026, 5:00 PM.

Head of the Section (ACIR)

RAJASTHAN RAJYA VIDYUT UTPADAN NIGAM LIMITED
CIN:- U40102RJ20005GCO16484 (A Govt. of Rajasthan Undertaking)
O/o CE (fuel), 6th Floor, LIC Jeevandeep Building, Lalkothi, Jaipur
E-TENDER NOTICE: TN-09/RVU26275LOB01367

Online Tenders are invited for Rate contract for taking delivery of raw coal from WCL collieries on behalf of RVUN, through transportation and loading of the same into Railway wagons for dispatch to RVUN's TIPSs and completing all documentation as required by Coal Company, Railways and RVUN for year 2026-27. Tender details are available on <http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in> (for e-tender), www.energy.rajasthan.gov.in/rvun1 & www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in.

Raj.Samwad/C26/11169 RVUN/PR-4482 Superintending Engineer (Fuel)

कार्यालय अतिथिगी अतिथिता सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग खण्ड-चित्रीडगढ़
क्रमांक / पीएच/2026-27/बी - 2388 दिनांक - 25.09.2026

NOTICE INVITING BID – 24/2026-27

Bids for Various CONSTRUCTION OF INDOOR STADIUM WORK AT KAPASAN DIST-CHITTORGARH. DLP Mention in Tender Documents in Division Chittorgarh Procurement are invited from interested Bidders up to 6.00 PM of 21.10.2026 Other particulars of the Bid may be visited on the Procurement Portal (<http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in>, <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>.) of the state website. The approximate value of the Procurement in Rs. **23742618.00**

NIB CODE **PWD2627A2989** (Naveen Kumar Agrawal)
UBN NO. 1 PWD2627WSOB13450 Executive Engineer
DIPR/C/16781/2026 PWD Dn, Chittorgarh



ICICI Prudential Life's Bagchi
named HDFC Bank MD, CEO

Coal India's production jumps 9.2% in September

UN urges more U.S. action on Marshall Islands' nuclear legacy



Russia's Putin says world is living through a dangerous moment



Dual U.K.-Iranian national arrested over airbase incident in England



Saudi-led coalition says Houthis attacked power station in Medina



Pakistan says it killed 22 militants in 'precise' strikes in Afghanistan

Iraq PM Zaidi sets deadline for Shia militias to disarm

Russian drones strike Kyiv nuclear research facility grounds, bridge

World undergoing profound structural changes: Japan Foreign Minister Motegi

Hegseth says U.S. cut number of Generals and Admirals by 20%

Sport

Pacers hold sway as 12 wickets fall on the opening day

Australia-A on top as host batters falter

The scores:
Australia-A 358 & 173/4 decl. in 49 overs (Sam Konstas 40, Jason Sangha 44 n.o.) vs. India-A 167 in 68 overs (Shaik Rasheed 42) & 28/1 in 13 overs.

DREAM FINAL

India thrashes Sri Lanka, sets up gold-medal match with Pakistan



PTI

Defending champion India hammered Sri Lanka by 124 runs in the Asian Games men's semifinal in Nisshin on Thursday to set up a gold-medal clash with Pakistan. **The scores:** India 169/7 in 20 overs (Sooryavanshi 38, Kishan 80 n.o., Ratnayake 2/32, Arachchige 2/28) bt Sri Lanka 45 in 9.5 overs (Bumrah 2/7, Axar 2/8, Abhishek 2/2).

FALLING SHORT

Indian squash teams end up with bronze after semifinal defeats



X@INDIASQUASH

Defending champion India lost 1-2 to Malaysia in the Asian Games men's semifinals, the lone win coming from Veer Chotrani, *in pic*. The women met the same fate against Hong Kong despite Tanvi Khanna's stirring comeback. The defeats ended the country's squash campaign in the team event with two bronze medals.

UNBEATEN SO FAR

India makes quadrant semifinals, assured of sepaktakraw medal



X@MEDIA_SA

India was assured of a sepaktakraw medal in the men's quadrant competition in Nagoya on Thursday after it entered the Asian Games semifinals with a 2-1 win over Myanmar, keeping an unbeaten run intact to top Group A. India had earlier defeated Laos and Vietnam in its first two matches.

BLISTERING SHOW

Second-placed Pranavi's 63 puts India in twin medal hunt



X@LETGOLF

Pranavi Urs fired a blistering seven-under 63 in the second round that catapulted her into sole second place (11-under 129), two shots behind leader Shannon Tan of Singapore, in the women's golf competition at the Asian Games in Nagoya. The women's team is now in the bronze-medal position at seven-under 273.

India holds off Pakistan in a thriller, enters final

The defending champion lets slip a three-goal lead before Abhishek's last-minute strike saves the day for the team; Malaysia ousts South Korea to reach the gold-medal contest

ASIAN GAMES

Uthra Ganesan GIFU

Relieved. The pre-dominant feeling in the Indian camp after sneaking past Pakistan 4-3 in the men's hockey semifinal of the Asian Games here on Thursday. A game of two halves and seemingly two different Indian teams turning up for each half.

With the scores tied 3-3 and 49 seconds to go, a shoot-out looming large in the first semifinal at the Gi-fu Prefectural Green Stadium, Abhishek's feeble push took a deflection off Sufyan's stick and the Pakistan team watched the ball roll past the goal line, crushing their dreams of advancing to the title clash yet again.

For the first 30 minutes, India played like the higher-ranked defending champion it is, despite a distinct lack of fluidity. The fifth



Man of the moment: Abhishek is the toast of his teammates after his winner. R.V. MOORTHY

saw Harmanpreet Singh slot the ball into the middle of the net and take the lead. By the 23rd minute it was 3-0, despite a goal being disallowed for coming off the back of Dilpreet's stick.

Pakistan, which had pulled one back 35 seconds from half-time through its sixth PC and skipper Abu Mahmood,

came out pumped up and took charge. Two goals in four minutes exposed the Indian fragility. Hannan Shahid tapped in in the 45th minute and Rana Waheed Ashraf restored parity, capitalising on a defensive lapse.

A fifth Asian title and a spot in the LA Olympics will be on the line when India takes on Malaysia in the

first-ever Asian Games final between the two sides after the latter got past Korea 2-1 in the other semifinal.

The results (semifinals): India 4 (Harmanpreet Singh 5-pc, 13-pc, Sukhjeet Singh 23-pc, Abhishek 60) bt Pakistan 3 (Abu Mahmood 30-pc, Hannan Shahid 45, Rana Waheed Ashraf 49); Malaysia 2 (Abu Kamal Azrai 40-pc, 45-ps) bt Korea 1 (Gangsan Lee 42).

Nitesh wins silver in 97kg Greco-Roman wrestling

Uthra Ganesan NAGOYA

Nitesh Siwach went down fighting in the final of the 97kg Greco-Roman wrestling but the 23-year-old had made history much before he stepped on the mat in the title clash. He became the sixth Indian Greco-Roman wrestler to reach the final of the Asian Games and the first in 64 years, the edition when the discipline was first introduced.

Nitesh began in style, winning 7-1 against Turkmenistan's Amanberdi Agamammedov in the quarterfinals. All his points were scored in the first three-minute period.

The semifinal was even more lopsided, Nitesh bulldozing his way past Mongolian Gankhuyag Ganbaatar 9-0.

Two massive four-point moves and then one for pushing his opponent off the mat were enough for the two-time Asian Championships medalist to storm into the final against



History-maker: Nitesh with coach Hargobind Singh after his remarkable display. PTI

local favourite Yuri Nakazato, last year's silver medalist at the Asians.

It was a close bout, Nakazato earning two single points in the first period for a narrow lead. Nitesh tried to counter in the second but ended up conceding two more to lose 0-4.

"I still can't believe it. My father told me there was no looking back once I started this journey and today I did it for him. There was a lot of pressure but I trusted my training and gave everything I had to make the country proud,"

Nitesh said after the bout.

In 77kg, Aman had to fight hard to win 8-6 against Borgil Tuvshinbaatar of Mongolia, courtesy a two-pointer in the last few seconds after trailing for long periods.

However, he went down tamely in the quarterfinals to Qatar's Shahin Badaghimofrad 0-9.

On the women's side, Mansi first went down 0-6 to Japan's two time World champion Nonoka Ozaki in the 62kg semis before losing 2-5 to Mongolia's Altjin Togtokh in the bronze medal match.

Ganesh earns bronze in compound archery

Press Trust of India NAGOYA

Indian compound archer Ganesh Mani Ratnam Thirumuru defeated Vietnam's Cong Duc Dang 149-144 in the men's bronze-medal playoff after a 144-148 semifinal loss to Kim Jongho of South Korea. Ganesh had defeated Taiwan's Chieh-Lun Chen 148-138 in the quarters. Among women, Chikitha Taniparthi lost 143-144 to Indonesia's Nurisa Dian Ashrifah in the last-eight stage.



Ganesh. REUTERS



Going strong: Noble and Francis in action. REUTERS

Francis-Noble clinch silver in men's skiff

Press Trust of India GAMAGORI CITY

The Indian pair of Manu Francis and Prince Kurisinal Noble bagged the silver medal in the men's skiff opening race 9 of the Asian Games sailing competition here on Thursday.

The 31-year-old Francis and the 30-year-old Noble, who hail from Ernakulam and are first cousins, combined for a total of 23 points after nine races and finished behind China's Wen Zaiding and Liu Tian, who totalled 16 in the competition where the lowest total wins the regatta.

Points in men's skiff sailing are decided by the finish position in each race and a first place brings in one point to the total. The Indians managed to win race three and finish second in race one, five and nine. China emerged on top in four races to end up as the best-placed side.

In the women's competition, Harshita Tomar and Shital Verma ended fourth and last after logging 26 points. Japan took gold with 11. The Indian combination could not win any of the nine races but managed to finish second in race three and four.

INDIANS IN ACTION		
A look at some Indian players/teams who will compete on Friday (all times IST):	semifinal: vs. Iran (10.55 a.m.); Medal matches (11.25 a.m. onwards).	Volleyball: Men (classification match 5th-8th): vs. South Korea, 6.30 a.m.
	Boxing: Finals: Women: 75kg: Lovlina vs. Ziyi (Chn), 10 a.m.; 65kg: Parveen vs. Nien-chin (Tpe), 2.15 p.m.; Men: 80kg: Ankush vs. Minseong (Kor), 2.45 p.m.	Wrestling: 1/8 finals: Women's 50kg: Dipanshi vs. Susaki (Jpn), 7.05 a.m.; Men's freestyle 125kg: Rajat vs. Kassimbek (Kaz), 7.25 a.m.; Women: 76kg: Priya vs. Kyzy (Kgz), 7.30 a.m.; Men's freestyle 65kg: Sujeet vs. Zazai (Afg), 8 a.m.
	Mixed team semifinal: vs. Japan (8.20 a.m.); Medal matches (8.50 a.m. onwards); Men's team	
	Archery: Recurve: Women's team semifinal: vs. China (5.55 a.m.); Medal matches (6.25 a.m. onwards).	

2027 ICC ODI World Cup schedule



GROUP A
India (A1), Australia (A2), Pakistan (A3), Afghanistan, Zimbabwe, Qualifier A

GROUP B
New Zealand (B1), South Africa (B2), Sri Lanka (B3), England, Bangladesh, Qualifier B



SUPER SERIES

DATE	TEAMS	VENUE
Oct. 2	QF1 vs. QF3	Windhoek
Oct. 4	QF1 vs. QF2	Windhoek
Oct. 6	QF2 vs. QF3	Windhoek

The top two (Qualifier A and B) will make it to the group stage

GROUP GAMES

Oct. 7	India vs. Australia	Cape Town
Oct. 8	Pakistan vs. Afghanistan	Tshwane
Oct. 8	England vs. Bangladesh	Windhoek
Oct. 9	Zimbabwe vs. Qualifier A	Bulawayo
Oct. 9	South Africa vs. New Zealand	Cape Town
Oct. 10	India vs. Pakistan	Johannesburg
Oct. 10	Sri Lanka vs. Qualifier B	Windhoek
Oct. 11	Zimbabwe vs. Afghanistan	Bulawayo
Oct. 12	Australia vs. Qualifier A	Paarl
Oct. 12	New Zealand vs. Bangladesh	KuGompo City
Oct. 13	England vs. Sri Lanka	Windhoek
Oct. 13	South Africa vs. Qualifier B	Paarl
Oct. 14	India vs. Afghanistan	Tshwane
Oct. 15	Pakistan vs. Qualifier A	Bloemfontein
Oct. 15	Zimbabwe vs. Australia	Harare
Oct. 16	Sri Lanka vs. Bangladesh	Durban
Oct. 16	South Africa vs. England	Gqeberha
Oct. 17	India vs. Qualifier A	Bloemfontein
Oct. 17	New Zealand vs. Qualifier B	Harare
Oct. 18	Australia vs. Afghanistan	KuGompo City
Oct. 19	Zimbabwe vs. Pakistan	Harare
Oct. 19	South Africa vs. Bangladesh	Durban
Oct. 20	New Zealand vs. Sri Lanka	Johannesburg
Oct. 20	England vs. Qualifier B	Harare
Oct. 21	Afghanistan vs. Qualifier A	KuGompo City
Oct. 22	Australia vs. Pakistan	Paarl
Oct. 22	South Africa vs. Sri Lanka	Johannesburg
Oct. 23	England vs. New Zealand	Gqeberha
Oct. 23	Bangladesh vs. Qualifier B	Tshwane
Oct. 24	Zimbabwe vs. India	Victoria Falls

SUPER SEMEN

Oct. 25	A2 vs. B3	Johannesburg
Oct. 26	B1 vs. A3	Gqeberha
Oct. 27	B2 vs. AB4*	Tshwane
Oct. 28	A1 vs. A2	Victoria Falls
Oct. 29	B1 vs. B3	KuGompo City
Oct. 30	A3 vs. AB4	Victoria Falls
Oct. 31	B2 vs. A1	Johannesburg
Nov. 1	A2 vs. B1	Victoria Falls
Nov. 2	B3 vs. AB4	Cape Town
Nov. 3	B2 vs. A3	Durban
Nov. 4	A1 vs. B1	Paarl
Nov. 5	A2 vs. AB4	Durban
Nov. 6	B2 vs. B3	Bloemfontein
Nov. 7	A1 vs. A3	Cape Town
Nov. 8	B1 vs. AB4	Durban
Nov. 9	B2 vs. A2	Gqeberha
Nov. 10	A3 vs. B3	Bloemfontein
Nov. 11	A1 vs. AB4	Gqeberha
Nov. 12	B2 vs. B1	Cape Town
Nov. 13	A2 vs. A3	Bloemfontein
Nov. 14	A1 vs. B3	Durban

* AB4 - Best fourth-placed side in Group A or B

THE LAST FOUR		
Nov. 17	Semifinal 1	Cape Town
Nov. 18	Semifinal 2	Tshwane
THE SUMMIT CLASH		
Nov. 21	Final	Johannesburg

Rohit — letting his bat do the talking

A year is still a long time in international sport and the opener will be nearly 40 and a half when the World Cup gets going. But he is the latest shining example of age being just a number

R. Kaushik

If the West Indian - and Indian - bowling fraternities currently doing battle in the One-Day International series decide to go on strike, they will be greeted with empathy, sympathy and understanding. If one thought Sunday's first game in Thiruvananthapuram was a tall-scoring affair - 595 runs in 91.4 overs, overall run-rate 6.51 - then how do you even begin to describe the massacre in Guwahati on Wednesday?

How often does a team boast three centurions and get beaten out of sight? If you said never, allow yourself a pat on the back. How often does a team rack up 405 and end by licking its wounds? If you said once before, another pat. Though, it must be said, each of these gentle pats will heap untold misery and psychological pain on the Caribbean bowling group.

The thousands at the ground and millions watching on television must have wondered at the wisdom of Shubman Gill's decision to stick the visitors in after West Indies rode on sparkling centuries from John Campbell, skipper Shai Hope and the free-flowing Amir Jangoo to amass 405 for seven. Only once before in the history of the game, more than a decade back, has a higher total been scaled down in ODI history. On that instance, South Africa rode on the incandescence of Herschelle Gibbs (175), and key contributions from Graeme Smith (90), Mark Boucher (50) and Johan van der Wath (35 off 18) to overhaul Australia's 434 for four with one wicket and one delivery to spare. A tantalisingly close contest with the result in doubt till the very final ball.

A sense of the inevitable

But not so in Guwahati. There was a sense of the inevitable when India began their reply. To have to score at more than eight an over from the off was a massive ask, on the face of it. Never mind how flat the track, how small the boundaries and how inexperienced the bowling attack, to reel in 405? Not easy, you'd think. Not by a long way. Well, think again.

Gill, perhaps determined to prove that his call to chase was the right one, no matter the mountain ahead of him, raced away with a Formula One beast, engines screaming, rubber burning. At the other end, his predecessor as India's captain purred along effortlessly, matching his partner for impact without resorting to the rambunctiousness that the man 12 years his junior was showcasing.

The artificial clouds of uncertainty that had been thrust above Rohit Sharma's head disappeared in a flurry of boundaries at Lord's some two and a half months back, when the right-hander produced his 34th ODI hundred. His subliminal 138 wasn't enough to help India overhaul England's 387 in the deciding game of the three-match series, but coming as it did just a day and a bit after BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia moved to quell speculations that Lord's would be his swansong, it was a statement of great intent and import.

Rohit would be less than human if he hadn't felt the heat going into Lord's. Not because his bat had gone cold, but because the expectations were extraordinarily unfair and demanding, the scrutiny unforgiving, the dissection brutal if without basis. He knew he still had it; he had worked hard to become the fittest version of himself (possibly ever) and it must have rankled that, for all his staggering accomplishments, he was still being put on trial.

Not used to outlandish statements or prickly gestures, Rohit took everything in his stride, silencing wagging tongues and the motley band of critics with the Lord's masterpiece. Only he can say if that effort freed him up mentally, but on Wednesday, Rohit was at it again, content to sail in Gill's wake, happy to keep up his end of the bargain and using all his experience, wisdom and intelligence to not try to compete with the fireworks emanating from the other end.

One of the great virtues of having played internationally for 19 years and represented the country in more than 500 matches is that you know your game inside out. You quickly sum up the conditions, you figure out rapidly what works and what may not. You decide which bowlers to target, which areas to score freely in.

Having spent 50 overs in the field chasing leather, Rohit knew that to hop on to the backfoot and play from there was a fruitful, productive, paying option. And that's exactly what he did, hanging just that touch back and letting loose without ever trying to overhit or muscle the ball as he kept his tryst with three-figures.

Gill's century was a spectacle, spanning just 62 deliveries and containing 10 fours and five sixes. It was as if he was batting on a different, stratospheric plane because that's how effortlessly easy on



RITU RAJ KONWAR

the eye he is. But what about Rohit? When has he not been easy on the eye himself? Ever?

Rohit's hundred came off 72 deliveries - stately it certainly wasn't. Of those 72 balls, 10 disappeared to the boundary, six over it. On its own, it was a compelling effort, a glorious compilation of some of the prettiest shots you will see on the cricket ground. Gill's luminescence eclipsed it a little, but only a little. When you set out in quest of 405, individual brilliance won't cut it. If India managed in the end to scale it down with a massive 39 balls to spare -- and with eight wickets in hand - put it down almost entirely to the opening salvo.

By the time Rohit fell leg before to Jayden Seales, he had breezed to 101, off 75 balls. More importantly, he had helped Gill put on 255, in just 158 deliveries. India were scoring at nearly 10 an over - pause, reflect and marvel - when the Mumbaier exited the middle of the ACA Stadium off to rapturous applause. Nary an emotion, just another evening in the office, and not a feeling of a job half-done because Rohit knew what incoming No. 3 Virat Kohli was capable of, what the depth in the batting order could translate to, and what was going through his successor's mind - stay till the finish, get the job done.

Celebratory jig

Rohit's celebratory jig during the single that took him from 99 to 100 has been much discussed in the last several hours. When he was asked about that not long after the winning run was struck, he refused to rise to the bait, saying, "I'll keep that celebration for myself. Some things are just

meant to be with you and it's not to be shared. So that was for me." And why not? Why, when he had chosen silence to stave off sniping teeth and malicious gossip, did he owe anyone any explanation about his celebration? Why indeed? Like Kohli had at the start of the series, Rohit also went public before the second ODI about his ambitions, about his quest for the elusive 50-over World Cup winner's medal. The former boasts one of those, having played a significant role when Mahendra Singh Dhoni's



men created history a decade and a half back by becoming the first host nation to go all the way. Kohli had smashed a century on his World Cup debut in Mirpur against Bangladesh and weighed in with a crucial hand in the final in Mumbai against Sri Lanka. Walking in at a wobbly 31 for the loss of Virender Sehwag and Sachin Tendulkar as India chased 275 for the title and history, he helped current coach Gautam Gambhir put on 83 for the third wicket before perishing for 35. Kohli was also the Player of the Final when Rohit hoisted the T20 World Cup trophy in Bridgetown two and a quarter years back, so he has the full set of white-ball winners' medals, so to say. Rohit holds two T20 World Cup champion medals - on debut in 2007 and on his swansong in 2024 - but having heartbreakingly missed out on selection in 2011, slammed five centuries in 2019 and stumbled at the final hurdle, as skipper, in 2023, he is determined, if not desperate, to make his final chance a telling, successful one.

Raging inner fire

A year is still a long time in international sport and Rohit will be nearly 40 and a half when the World Cup gets going. But he is the latest shining example of age being just a number. Driven by a raging inner fire and happily immune to the goings-on around him, his goal is palpable, his focus narrow, his vision understandably blinkered. In New Zealand in November, when the final preparatory exercise will get underway, he will get five opportunities to refamiliarise himself with the conditions that can be expected to be on offer in Africa.

By his own admission, because he only plays one format internationally, he has the time to revisit his game and deep-dive into analysis, something that constant travel and the hectic hustle and bustle of non-stop cricket can sometimes preclude.

Headspace has never been a problem with Rohit. He might have spent much of his career in Kohli's shadow and was eclipsed by Gill on Wednesday, but Rohit isn't the sort to dwell on these little things. He has the remarkable ability to always keep the larger picture in mind which, coupled with his experience, his nous and his hunger, make him a cherished teammate and a doubly dangerous opponent.

THE GIST

The artificial clouds of uncertainty that had been thrust above Rohit's head disappeared in a flurry of boundaries at Lord's some two and a half months back, when the right-hander produced his 34th ODI hundred

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HEALTH

What human brain tissue transplanted into mice showed us

A Stanford University experiment called 'xenocortication' lets human brain tissue develop inside a living mouse, offering a new way to study the developing human brain and, potentially, how disease develops; it also raises new ethical questions about how far such experiments should go

C. Aravinda
Veera Rajagopal

A study published in September in *Nature* by neuroscientist Sergiu Pasca's group at Stanford University reports an experiment that sounds almost like science fiction. Human brain tissue grown from stem cells was transplanted into mice in which much of the cerebral cortex had been genetically prevented from forming. The transplanted tissue grew into this vacant space, produced several types of human brain cells, became electrically active, connected with the mouse nervous system and was associated with measurable differences in behaviour.

Yet, there was an important limitation. The researchers did not create a human brain inside a mouse. The transplanted tissue remained immature, lacked the ordered structure of a normal human cortex, and the study cannot establish that human neurons directly caused any particular behaviour. What the experiment offers is a narrow glimpse of human brain development as it unfolds inside a non-human living nervous system. Understanding how the human brain develops matters both for evolutionary biology and for medicine. The cerebral cortex expanded greatly during human evolution, developing specialised cells and connections involved in language, planning and complex social behaviour. Studying how these features emerge may help explain what makes the human brain distinctive.

It is also medically important because many neurological and psychiatric disorders may begin during development, long before symptoms appear. The main challenge is access. Scientists cannot experimentally manipulate a developing human brain as they can in laboratory animals.

Stem cell technology opened up another avenue to study the developing human brain. Scientists can take ordinary human cells, re-programme them into an earlier, flexible state called induced pluripotent stem cells, and guide them to become nerve cells. When these cells are grown together in three dimensions, they can organise into structures called organoids.

A brain organoid is a small piece of laboratory-grown neural tissue that reproduces some features of early brain development. Organoids allow researchers to observe how human neurons develop, introduce disease-related genetic changes and test responses to drugs.

However, tissue grown in a lab dish lacks key features of a living brain, including normal blood circulation, sensory inputs and long-distance connections with other parts of the nervous system. Researchers, including the Stanford group, have therefore transplanted human brain organoids into rodents. Yet this creates another constraint: the rodent already has its own cortex, so the transplanted human tissue



New findings: What the experiment offers is a narrow glimpse of human brain development as it unfolds inside a non-human living nervous system. Understanding how the human brain develops matters both for evolutionary biology and for medicine. GETTY IMAGES

must compete for limited space and neural connections, and has never amounted to more than a fragment of the host's brain.

A third window

The Stanford researchers opened up a third possibility. Instead of engineering a better graft, they re-engineered the host. Using genetic techniques, they produced mice in which much of the neocortex and hippocampus never formed. Because the mice were also bred to lack a functioning immune system, the human tissue would not be rejected. Human cortical organoids were then transplanted into the vacant space soon after birth. The researchers call the approach xenocortication. 'Xeno' refers to something originating from another species, while the cortex is the outer region of the brain involved in many higher functions.

In the Stanford experiment, freed from much of the competition from mouse cortical tissue, the human grafts expanded substantially, and by three months, they made up about 92% of the animal's cortical tissue. They produced several types of developing cortical neurons, along with progenitor cells and astrocytes, at a stage of maturity roughly equivalent to that of the human cortex late in the second trimester of pregnancy. The grafts generated deep-layer neurons carrying the molecular signature of von Economo neurons, large, distinctively shaped cells found in humans and a few other large-brained mammals, but absent in rodents.

The grafts also became electrically active, producing slow waves that swept across the tissue every few minutes, a pattern characteristic of developing, rather than mature, cortical networks. They formed connections with surviving parts of the mouse nervous system, and human nerve fibres reached as far as the

cervical spinal cord, something not seen in mice with an intact cortex. This is the conceptual leap of the study: human neural tissue was no longer a fragment lodged inside a rodent's brain, but tissue occupying almost all of the space where that animal's cortex would have been.

The next question was whether this integration had any functional effect. The starting point was itself surprising. Mice lacking most of their neocortex and hippocampus (roughly half the brain by volume) remained active and mobile.

To detect subtler differences, the researchers combined conventional behavioural tests with a machine-learning system called Motion Sequencing (MoSeq). By this measure, mice lacking much of their cortex behaved differently from normal animals. Xenocortical mice showed an intermediate pattern, suggesting that transplantation altered behaviour without fully restoring it.

Why this matters

To show what the platform can do, the researchers exposed the mice to five hours of severe oxygen deprivation. The response was confined to the human tissue: a molecular marker of oxygen stress appeared in the graft but not in the adjacent mouse brain, and not at all in animals without a graft. Two days later, the xenocortical mice walked differently, shifting to a more stable stance without any change in their speed. Imaging 10 days on showed changes in the graft's blood vessels. Under the microscope, the graft's supporting cells had multiplied and become more complex.

This creates a potentially powerful experimental pathway. Scientists could introduce a disease-related mutation into human cells, allow the resulting neural tissue to develop within a living nervous system, observe changes in cells and circuits, assess whether behaviour is affected, and then test possible

treatments. Such models could help study developmental brain disorders, the oxygen deprivation around birth that can lead to cerebral palsy, human-specific neuronal diseases and evolutionary differences between human and animal brains. They may also provide a platform for drug testing and, eventually, for evaluating regenerative or cell-based treatments for severe early brain injury.

Limits and ethics

The model is still far from reproducing a developing human brain. Although anatomical connections were observed, this does not prove that they directly controlled behaviour. Any behavioural changes, therefore, arise from a hybrid system in which human tissue interacts with the remaining mouse brain.

These scientific limits also shape the ethical questions. There is no evidence the animals developed a human-like mind, but future grafts may be larger, more mature and better integrated. At what point might this alter an animal's cognition, perception or capacity for experience in ethically significant ways? The researchers anticipated this question and consulted bioethicists at Stanford before beginning. The paper argues that going further towards grafts with mature cortical layering, or transplantation into embryos or into non-human primates, will require a greater degree of scrutiny before such experiments begin.

Ultimately, xenocortication is important not because it creates a human brain in another species, but because it may provide a third window to study human brain development.

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THE GIST

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Temperament, adversity may offer clues to psychiatric vulnerability: study

Afshan Yasmeen

Temperamental traits and adverse experiences during childhood may together offer clues to vulnerability to major psychiatric disorders, a transdiagnostic study by researchers at NIMHANS, Bengaluru has found.

The study, published recently in the *Journal of Affective Disorders*, examined 1,162 adults, including 532 people with psychiatric disorders, 457 unaffected first-degree relatives (FDRs) and 173 healthy controls. The participants were drawn from 393 multiplex families – families in which multiple members had been diagnosed with psychiatric disorders – involving schizophrenia, bipolar disorder, obsessive-compulsive disorder (OCD) and alcohol use disorder (AUD).

The researchers examined four broad dimensions of adult temperament – negative affectivity, extraversion/surgency, effortful control and orienting sensitivity – along with adverse childhood experiences (ACEs).

“Our findings suggest that temperament does not map onto psychiatric disorders in a simple,

one-to-one manner. Rather, different combinations of temperamental characteristics are associated with different disorders, and some of these characteristics are also seen among unaffected family members,” said Srinivas Balachander, corresponding author and one of the lead researchers of the study.

Using data from the erstwhile Accelerator programme for Discovery in Brain disorders using Stem cells (ADBS) project, (funded by the Department of Biotechnology and Pratiksha Trust), now known as the Rohini Nilekani Centre for Brain and Mind, at NIMHANS, the researchers found evidence of familial sharing across all four temperamental domains.

This was observed despite considerable variation in the psychiatric diagnoses within the same families. The finding is of interest because temperament is known to have a substantial heritable component, although the study did not directly establish that the temperamental characteristics observed were caused by specific genetic variants. “In our study, considering the significant within-family heterogeneity in terms



Finding a link: The researchers also examined whether adverse childhood experiences altered the relationship between temperament and psychiatric disorders. GETTY IMAGES

of different diagnoses, there was still a significant degree of shared temperament,” Dr. Balachander said.

Among affected participants, schizophrenia and bipolar disorder were associated with lower extraversion/surgency and orienting sensitivity. OCD was associated with higher negative affectivity and orienting sensitivity, along with lower effortful control and extraversion/surgency. Participants with AUD showed higher negative affectivity and orienting sensitivity and lower effortful control.

The researchers also examined whether adverse childhood experiences altered the relationship between temperament and psychiatric disorders.

The clearest evidence for an interaction between temperament and childhood adversity emerged in alcohol use disorder. The overall ACE score was significantly associated with AUD, and interactions between childhood adversity and two temperamental domains – extraversion/surgency and effortful control – were also

observed. “Childhood adversity appears to add another layer to the relationship between temperament and psychiatric vulnerability. In our study, the evidence for this interaction was particularly apparent in alcohol use disorder, rather than uniformly across all four disorders,” Dr. Balachander said.

The researchers, however, cautioned against interpreting the findings as evidence that a particular temperament or childhood experience causes a psychiatric disorder.

The study was cross-sectional, meaning that the assessments were made at one point in time. Reports of childhood adversity may also be affected by recall and measurement biases.

Testing the findings

To examine whether the findings extended beyond the genetically enriched family sample, the researchers tested their statistical model using an independent community-based cohort from the Consortium for Vulnerability to Externalizing Disorders and Addiction (c-VEDA).

The analysis included 2,485 adults

aged 18 to 23 years for whom the relevant temperament, ACE and psychiatric assessments were available.

The model showed an area under the curve (AUC) of 0.822 for alcohol use disorder, 0.742 for bipolar disorder and 0.752 for OCD. Its performance for schizophrenia was close to chance level, with an AUC of 0.526.

“The external validation gives us some indication that the associations identified in the family-based sample may extend to community populations for some disorders,” Dr. Balachander said.

The researchers said the findings point to the need for prospective studies that follow unaffected family members over time. Such studies could help determine whether particular temperamental characteristics precede the onset of psychiatric illness or are partly consequences of illness and its treatment.

The researchers stressed that the present findings do not establish that these measures can predict who will develop a psychiatric disorder.

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